Chapter 10 — Data Modeling and ER Diagrams

Up to now the tables in this book were handed to you. In real work nobody hands you tables: somebody describes a business in a few sentences ("we rent bikes to people"), and you must decide what to store, how the pieces connect, and which rules the database should enforce. That decision is **data modeling**, and it matters more than any single query you will write, because any fact left out of the model is a question no SQL, however clever, can ever answer.

This chapter walks the whole path: from a plain-language brief, to a drawing that business people can check (an **ER diagram**), to precise tables with keys and constraints (the **relational model**), to `CREATE TABLE` statements running on PostgreSQL. Chapter 11 then tests those tables for repeated data, and Chapter 17 applies everything to nine full case studies.

What you'll learn

1. What a data model is, who reads it, and the three levels it is drawn at (conceptual, logical, physical).
2. A repeatable seven-step modeling process, and the best practices that separate easy-to-change models from painful ones.
3. The ER model: entities, the five kinds of attribute, relationships, degree, cardinality, participation, relationship attributes and weak entities — in **Chen notation** and in **crow's-foot notation** (the one `mermaid erDiagram` draws).
4. A complete worked example: an employee-management ER diagram built step by step.
5. The relational model: relations, tuples, attributes, domains, `NULL`, the seven kinds of key and the integrity constraints.
6. The mechanical procedure that turns any ER diagram into tables, and the judgement calls it leaves to you.

All runnable code is in `code/`: `00_schema.sql` builds a small bike-rental database; `01`–`04` run on a fresh database each (see Chapter 1 for the private PostgreSQL 14 server). Every "Output:" block below is real psql output.

10.1 What data modeling is

What it is

Data modeling is deciding three things before you write any SQL:

Part	Plain meaning	Usually becomes
Entity	a *thing* you keep data about (Customer, Bike, Rental) — almost always a noun	a table
Attribute	one *fact* about an entity (a customer's email, a bike's frame number)	a column
Relationship	a *link* between entities (a customer *rents* a bike)	a foreign key, or a table of its own

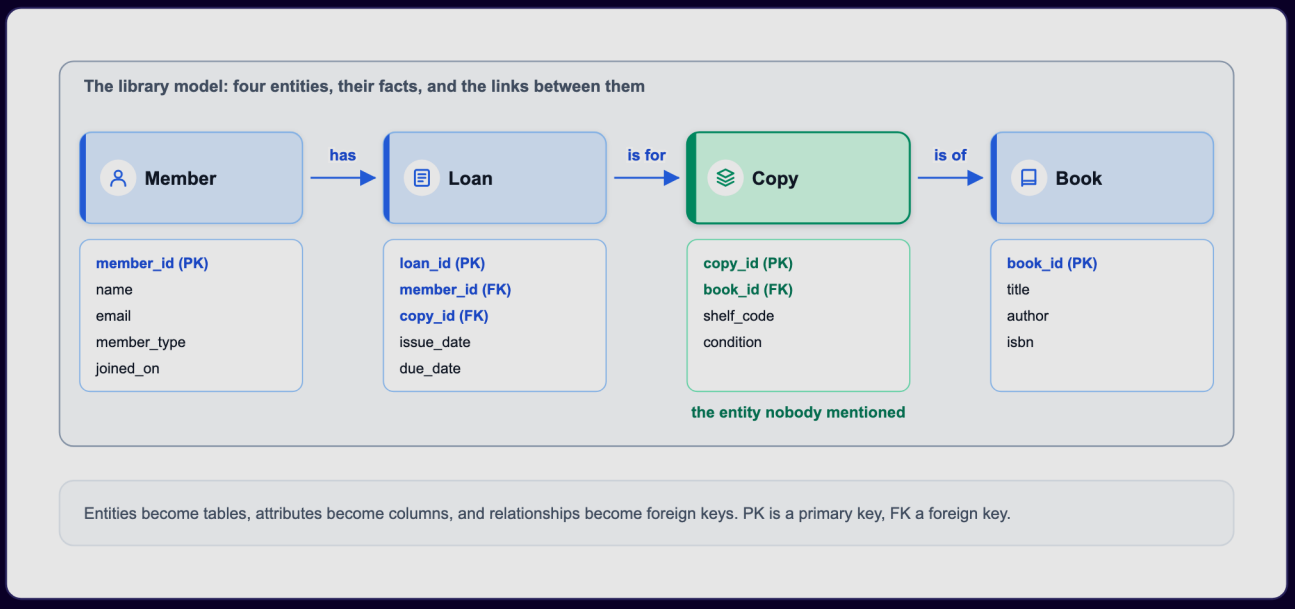
The result — a **data model** — is a picture of those three things and nothing else. It says nothing about indexes, `VARCHAR` lengths or which database product you will use. Analogy: it is the architect's floor plan, drawn before anyone picks brick suppliers.

The problem it solves — the question you cannot answer

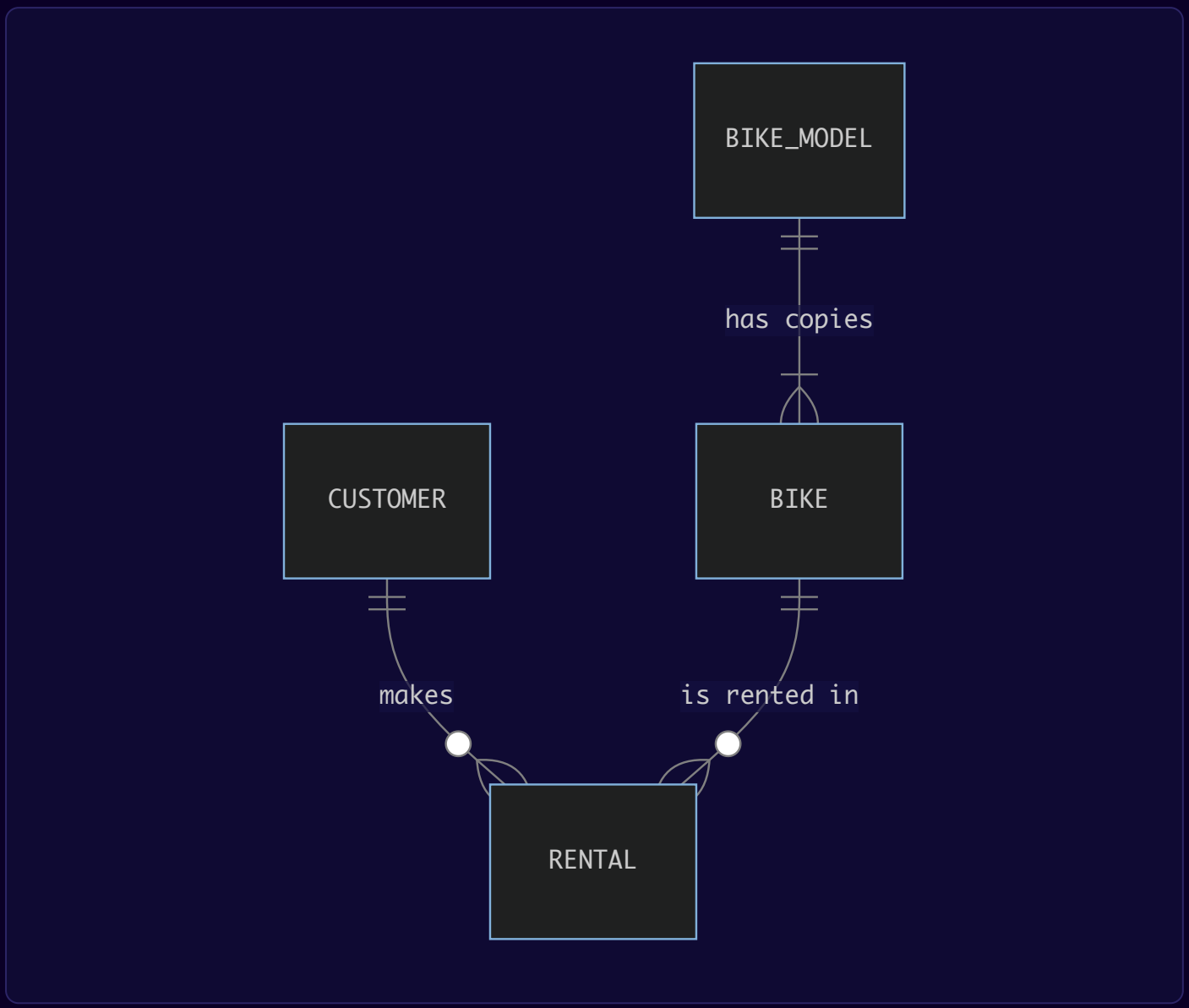
A small bike-rental shop says: *"We rent bikes to customers."* That sounds like two tables, `customer` and `bike`. Then the owner asks: *"We own three 'Urban 3' bikes. One came back with a bent wheel — which one, and who had it?"*

If your `bike` table actually describes a **model** of bike (name, type, hourly rate), it cannot answer. The physical object with a frame number is a different thing from the product it is an example of. Add a separate entity for the physical bike and the question becomes a short join. The code got no smarter; the database simply began recording one more fact.

Figure — the same idea in the course's library example: a Book (a title) is not a Copy (the object on the shelf) (course diagram)



The bike shop's model therefore has four entities: `customer`, `bike_model` (the "title"), `bike` (the physical object) and `rental` (who had which bike, when).



Who reads a data model

Reader	What they check
Business people (shop owner, registrar, librarian)	"Is anything missing? Are the rules right?" – they spot a forgotten entity in seconds
Developers	which tables exist and what each one means
Database administrators	storage, indexes, backups (mostly at the physical level)
Analysts	where each fact lives, so reports are correct

Since non-technical readers must follow it, you describe the model in everyday language first and add technical detail afterwards – which is why §10.2 has three levels.

What data modeling is *not*

- **Not writing SQL.** SQL comes last and is nearly mechanical once the model is right (§10.15).
- **Not performance tuning.** Indexes and query plans come later (Chapter 12). Quickly answering the wrong question helps nobody.
- **Not application code.** Two very different apps can share one model.

Why it matters

- **Fewer wrong answers** – rules in the model become constraints that every program must obey.
- **Less repeated data** – each fact stored once cannot contradict itself.
- **Cheaper change** – a model that matches reality absorbs new requirements; one that doesn't fights each of them.
- **Shared vocabulary** – when the team says "rental", everyone means the same thing.

TL;DR

A data model = entities (things) + attributes (facts) + relationships (links). Entities → tables, attributes → columns, relationships → foreign keys. If the model does not hold a fact, no query can recover it.

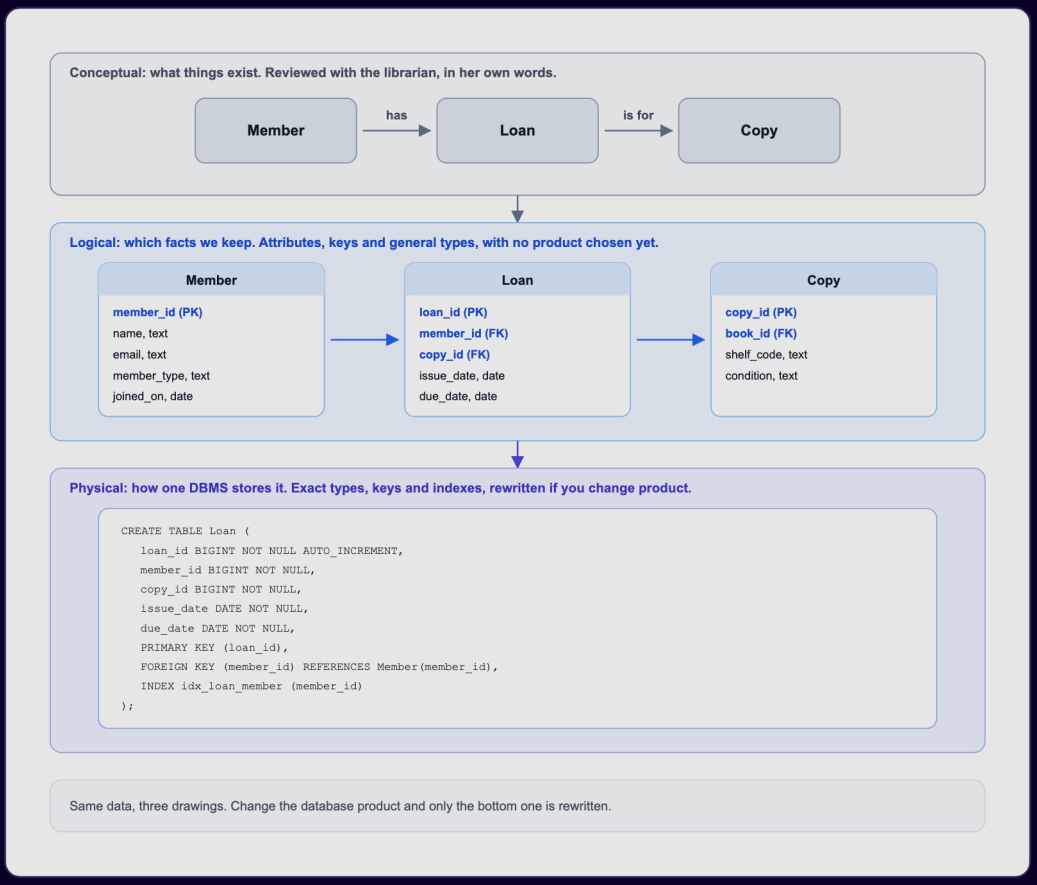
10.2 The three levels of a data model

What it is

The same model is drawn three times, each time with more detail, for a different audience:

	Conceptual	Logical	Physical
Shows	entities and relationships only	+ attributes, keys, general types (text/number/date)	+ exact types, indexes, partitioning, storage options
Detail	low	medium	high
Main audience	business people	designers, developers	DBAs, developers
Tied to a DBMS product?	no	no	**yes**
Question it answers	"Is every thing present, and is each link correct?"	"Which facts are recorded, and which keys join the tables?"	"How do we store this well on *this* database?"
Bike-shop example	Customer *rents* Bike; Bike *is of* BikeModel	`rental(rental_id, customer_id → customer, bike_id → bike, out_at, due_at, back_at)`	`CREATE TABLE rental (... timestamp ..., INDEX on customer_id)`

Figure – the same data at the three levels (course diagram)



How it works

1. **Conceptual** – boxes and lines, in the users' own words. Technology-independent: it would be equally valid for a relational database, a document store or a paper ledger.
2. **Logical** – add attributes, primary and foreign keys, and general types. This is where **normalization** happens (removing repeated data – Chapter 11). Still product-neutral.
3. **Physical** – rewrite for one DBMS: `bigint` vs `int`, `numeric(6,2)`, `timestamp`, indexes for the known queries, identity columns, partitioning.

The physical version of the rental table from `code/00_schema.sql`:

```
CREATE TABLE rental (
  rental_id   bigint GENERATED ALWAYS AS IDENTITY PRIMARY KEY,
  customer_id bigint      NOT NULL REFERENCES customer(customer_id),
  bike_id     bigint      NOT NULL REFERENCES bike(bike_id),
  out_at      timestamp   NOT NULL,
  due_at      timestamp   NOT NULL,
  back_at     timestamp,                          -- NULL = bike still out (meaningful NULL)
  CHECK (due_at > out_at),
  CHECK (back_at IS NULL OR back_at >= out_at)
);
CREATE INDEX rental_customer_idx ON rental(customer_id);   -- "rentals of this customer"
CREATE INDEX rental_bike_idx     ON rental(bike_id);       -- "who has this bike"
```

The entity came from the conceptual model, the columns and keys from the logical model; only the exact types, the identity column and the two indexes are physical decisions. Identity syntax differs by product, which is exactly why this level is product-specific:

Auto-numbered key	Syntax
PostgreSQL 10+	`bigint GENERATED ALWAYS AS IDENTITY` (older: `bigserial`)
MySQL	`BIGINT AUTO_INCREMENT`
SQLite	`INTEGER PRIMARY KEY` (becomes the rowid)
SQL Server	`BIGINT IDENTITY(1,1)`

Why bother with three levels

- **Every reader gets a version pitched at them.** A shop owner reviewing three boxes finds a missing entity; the same person shown `CREATE TABLE` finds nothing.
- **Mistakes are caught while cheap.** A missing entity costs a conversation at the conceptual level and a migration once two million rows exist.
- **Technology is isolated.** Switch from MySQL to PostgreSQL and only the physical model is rewritten. This is **data independence** (defined in Chapter 1) applied at design time.

The levels are not a one-way street: working out the logical model often shows the conceptual one was wrong, and you go back. That is cheap precisely because the conceptual drawing is small.

Common mistakes

- Showing column types to business reviewers (they stop reading).
- Calling a diagram with attributes and keys "conceptual" — once keys appear it is logical.
- Treating logical and physical as the same: *logical = what the business needs; physical = how one product stores it.*

Self-check

1. Which level first shows primary keys? → **Logical.**
2. You migrate from SQL Server to PostgreSQL. Which levels change? → **Only the physical.**
3. Where does normalization happen? → **Logical level.**

TL;DR

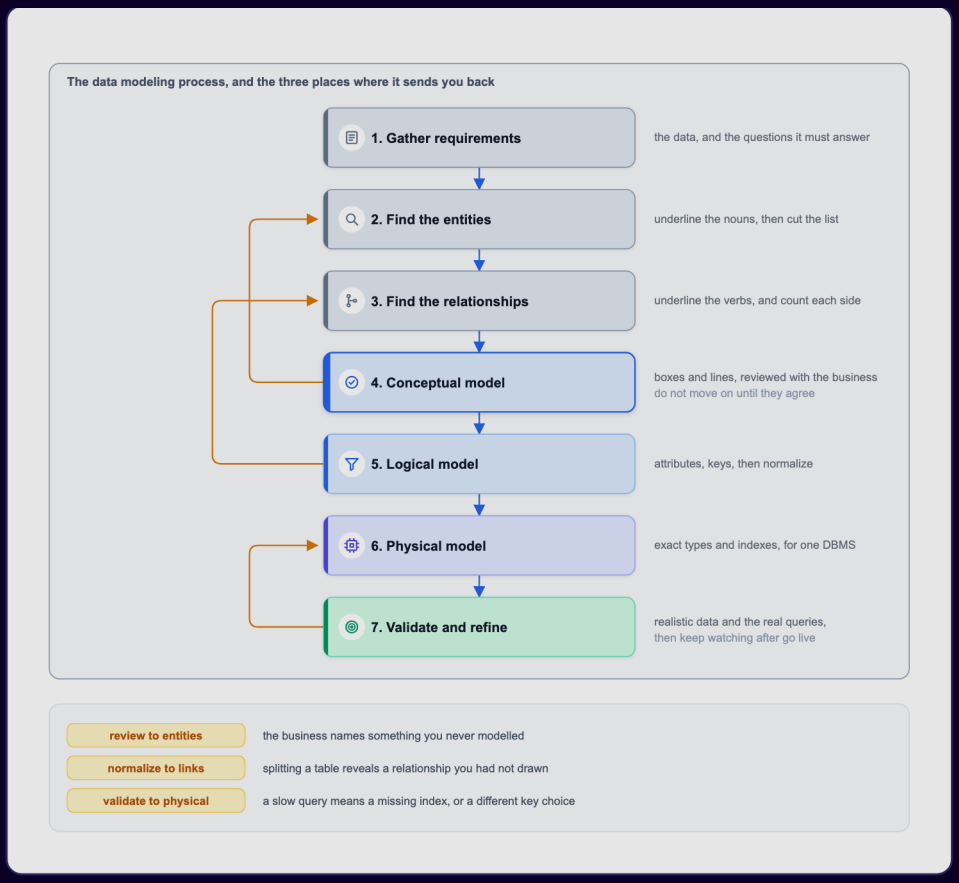
Conceptual (things + links, for the business) → logical (attributes, keys, general types, normalized) → physical (exact types, indexes, one DBMS). Only the physical level depends on the product.

10.3 The data modeling process

What it is

A fixed order of work where every step produces something you can show someone. Starting with tables is the classic mistake — it fixes the answer before you understand the question.

Figure — seven steps and the three places the work loops back (course diagram)



How it works — the bike shop, step by step

1. **Gather requirements — including the questions.** Talk to the people doing the work. Write down what must be recorded *and* what the system must answer:
   - Customers are casual or members; members may keep a bike longer.
   - The shop owns several physical bikes of each model.
   - A customer takes a bike at a time and must return it by a due time.
   - Late returns cost 2.00 per started hour.
   - Staff must see which bikes are out and who has them.

   An unanswerable question is a bug in the design, and right now it costs nothing to fix.
2. **Find the entities: underline the nouns.** customer, member, model, bike, time, fee, staff. Keep a noun as an entity only if you store *several facts* about it and there are *many instances* of it:
   - customer, bike_model, bike, rental → entities.
   - time → one value → an attribute.
   - casual/member → two kinds of customer → start with a `customer_type` attribute.
   - late fee → calculable from times → a **derived** value (§10.6), not stored.
   - staff → users of the system, not necessarily data in it.
3. **Find the relationships: underline the verbs between nouns.** customer *rents* bike; bike *is of* bike_model. For each, ask "how many on each side?" (cardinality, §10.7) and write it in words: one customer has many rentals; each rental is for one bike.
4. **Draw and review the conceptual model** with the owner, reading it back as sentences. She will correct you ("customers can also *reserve* a bike for tomorrow") — a new entity for the price of one box. Do not continue until the business agrees.
5. **Design the logical model.** Attributes, primary keys, foreign keys, general types; then normalize.
6. **Build the physical model.** Exact types, and an index for every question from step 1 (`rental.customer_id`, `rental.bike_id`).
7. **Validate, implement, refine.** Load realistic volumes (not ten rows — enough rows for slowness to show up), run the step-1 questions, check correctness and speed. After go-live keep watching: a model right for 10

thousand rentals may need a new index at 10 million.

The loops back are part of the process

Trigger	Sends you back to
Stakeholder review reveals something new (reservations)	step 2 (entities)
Normalization splits a table and exposes a hidden link	step 3 (relationships)
Validation finds a slow query	step 6 (index or key choice)

Looping back is the method working, not failing: every loop costs less than releasing the error.

Trade-offs to keep in mind throughout

- **Normalize vs denormalize** – normalize first; add redundancy back only for a measured slow query (Chapter 11).
- **Growth** – rows in three years, not today; it changes key and index choices.
- **Access control** – mark sensitive data early (emails, payments).
- **Integrity** – each business rule you collected in step 1 belongs in a constraint, not in an `if` inside the application.

The model answering the step-1 questions (`code/01_bike_questions.sql`)

```sql
-- Q1: which bikes are out right now, and who has them?
SELECT b.frame_no, m.model_name, c.full_name, r.due_at
FROM rental r
JOIN bike b       ON b.bike_id = r.bike_id
JOIN bike_model m ON m.model_id = b.model_id
JOIN customer c   ON c.customer_id = r.customer_id
WHERE r.back_at IS NULL
ORDER BY b.frame_no;
-- Q2: bikes never rented (NOT EXISTS anti-join)   Q4: late fee, derived at read time
SELECT r.rental_id, c.full_name,
       ceil(extract(epoch FROM (r.back_at - r.due_at)) / 3600) * 2.00 AS late_fee
FROM rental r JOIN customer c USING (customer_id)
WHERE r.back_at > r.due_at;
```

Output:

```
--- Q1: which bikes are out right now, and who has them?
 frame_no | model_name |  full_name   |       due_at
----------+------------+--------------+---------------------
 FR-2001  | Ridge 29   | Meera Nair   | 2026-09-27 18:00:00
 FR-3001  | Volt City  | Lena Fischer | 2026-09-27 10:30:00
(2 rows)

--- Q2: which physical bikes have never been rented?
 frame_no | model_name
----------+------------
 FR-1002  | Urban 3
 FR-1003  | Urban 3
(2 rows)

--- Q3: how many bikes of each model exist, and how many are out?
 model_name | bikes | out_now
------------+-------+---------
 Ridge 29   |     1 |       1
 Urban 3    |     3 |       0
 Volt City  |     1 |       1
(3 rows)

--- Q4: late returns, with a late fee of 2.00 per started hour (fee is derived, not stored)
 rental_id | full_name  | late_fee
-----------+------------+----------
         2 | Tom Okafor |     2.00
(1 row)
```

Q2 and Q3 are only possible because `bike` (the physical object) is separate from `bike_model`.

In the interview

30-second answer: "I start from requirements *and the questions the system must answer*. Nouns give candidate entities, verbs give relationships. I draw a conceptual model and review it with the business, then add attributes and keys and normalize (logical), then choose types and indexes for the target database (physical), and validate with realistic data and the real queries. I expect to loop back."

- *How do you decide whether a noun is an entity or an attribute?* → Entity if it carries several facts and has many instances; a single value (a date, a colour) is an attribute.
- *When do you add indexes?* → At the physical level, for the queries written down in requirements — not "on every column".

TL;DR

Requirements (+ questions) → nouns = entities → verbs = relationships → conceptual review → logical (keys, normalize) → physical (types, indexes) → validate with real data; loop back when reality disagrees.

10.4 Best practices in data modeling

Two models can both work on day one and differ enormously a year later. The difference comes from small early decisions. Here are the rules, each with the reason.

Practice	Rule	Why
Questions first	Write the list of questions before drawing.	A model is only "correct" relative to the questions it must answer.
Rules in the database	Every stated rule → a `PRIMARY KEY`, `FOREIGN KEY`, `NOT NULL`, `UNIQUE` or `CHECK`.	A constraint protects every program that ever connects, including tomorrow's ad-hoc script; an `if` protects only the program it is in.
One naming convention	Decide once (`snake_case`, singular *or* plural tables) and never mix. Same thing = same name everywhere (`customer_id`, never `cust_no` elsewhere). Name FKs after their target.	Joins read naturally; nobody has to guess.
Types on purpose	Dates as `date` / `timestamp`, never text; money as `numeric`, never `float` / `double`; text sized for real data. Prefer the narrowest type that fits.	Text dates accept "31 February" and sort wrongly; floating point cannot represent most decimals exactly, so totals drift; narrower rows = more rows per page = fewer disk reads.
Decide what NULL means	`NOT NULL` whenever the fact must exist; allow `NULL` only when "missing" is meaningful (`back_at IS NULL` = bike still out).	`NULL` means unknown/not applicable, is not `0` or `''` and is not equal to anything (§10.12).
Keys deliberately	Surrogate primary key + `UNIQUE` on the natural key (`email`, `frame_no`). Keep keys narrow.	Natural values change; a PK is copied into every FK and index.
Normalize, then denormalize with evidence	Default to 3NF; denormalize only after a measured slow query that an index could not fix – and document why.	Redundant copies can disagree (Chapter 11).
Index for real queries	Index what the requirement questions filter/join on; nothing else.	Every index slows every write and costs disk.
Design for predictable growth	Estimate rows in 3 years; don't build tables for imagined requirements.	Speculative tables become the parts nobody understands.
Document meaning	For each entity/column: what it means, allowed values, units.	Anyone can see `status` is text; only docs say which 4 values it holds.

The CHECK constraints in the bike schema are this practice in action: a rental due before it starts, or returned before it left, is refused for every client.

```
CHECK (due_at > out_at),
CHECK (back_at IS NULL OR back_at >= out_at)
```

Common mistakes

- **A list in one column** – `phones = '555-1, 555-2'` cannot be searched, counted or constrained → separate table.
- **Numbered columns** – `phone1, phone2, phone3` stores a list across columns and breaks the day someone owns a fourth phone.
- **One huge table** – 60 columns, mostly empty per row, is several entities that were never separated.
- **Over-normalizing** – seven joins for an everyday question is a real cost; 3NF is the usual stopping point.
- **Rules only in code** – some other program will break them.

Real-world examples

- **Stripe's API** represents amounts as integers in the smallest currency unit (cents) – the same idea as "never float for money".
- **ISO country codes** are `char(2)` – "size text for the data" in the wild.

TL;DR

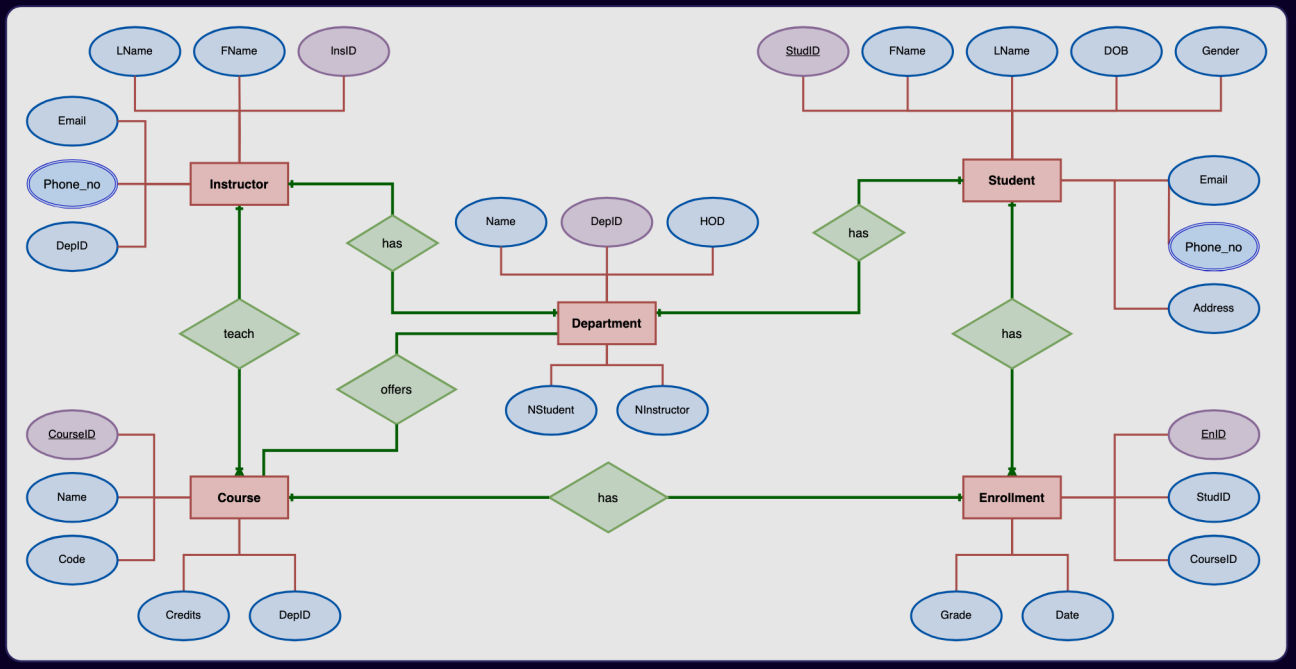
Questions first; constraints in the schema; one naming style; correct types (dates as dates, money as `numeric`); explicit `NOT NULL`; surrogate PK + unique natural key; normalize to 3NF, denormalize with measurements; index only real queries; document meaning.

10.5 The Entity-Relationship (ER) model and its notations

What it is

The **Entity-Relationship model** (ER model), proposed by Peter Chen in 1976, lets you sketch entities, attributes and relationships on paper long before you create a table. An **ER diagram (ERD)** is one such drawing. It is how you draw the conceptual model (entities + relationships only) and then the logical model (the same diagram with attributes, keys and cardinalities added). It never names a DBMS.

Figure – a complete Chen-notation ER diagram for a student management system; by §10.10 you can read every symbol (course diagram)



Two notations for the same model

	Chen notation	Crow's-foot notation (IE / Martin)
Entity	rectangle	rectangle with a title bar
Attribute	ellipse attached by a line	a row listed *inside* the rectangle
Relationship	diamond labelled with a verb	the line itself, labelled with a verb
Cardinality	`1`, `N`, `M` written near the diamond (or `(min,max)` pairs)	the *shape* of each line end (see table below)
Participation	double line = total, single = partial	inner symbol: bar = at least one, circle = may be zero
Used by	textbooks, exams, teaching	nearly every design tool (dbdiagram, MySQL Workbench, ERwin, Lucidchart), and `mermaid erDiagram`
Strength	shows the concepts explicitly	compact; fits 40 tables on a screen

Neither is "more correct". Learn Chen to understand the concepts; you will read crow's foot immediately afterwards. In this book the course's Chen figures show the concepts, and every schema is also drawn in crow's foot with mermaid.

Reading crow's-foot line ends – each end has an *outer* symbol (maximum) and an *inner* symbol (minimum):

Mermaid syntax (left end / right end)	Picture	Meaning (min, max)
`|o` / `o|`	circle + bar	zero or one `(0,1)`
`||` / `||`	bar + bar	exactly one `(1,1)`
`}o` / `o{`	circle + crow's foot	zero or more `(0,N)`
`}|` / `|{`	bar + crow's foot	one or more `(1,N)`

So `CUSTOMER ||--o{ RENTAL : makes` reads: *each rental belongs to exactly one customer; a customer makes zero or more rentals*. Strictly, mermaid draws a solid line `--` for an **identifying** relationship (the child's key includes the parent's – a weak entity, §10.9) and a dashed line `..` for a non-identifying one. This book draws every line solid for readability; a weak entity is recognised by a PK that contains the owner's key.

Strengths and limits of an ERD

- **Good at:** making the things, their links and the counts on each link visible, so even a non-technical reviewer notices what is missing.
- **Not a table diagram:** a single M:N diamond turns into *three* tables (§10.7).
- **Not a performance document:** no indexes or storage.
- **Not a process diagram:** it says a student enrols in a course, not which screens or approvals happen.

> **TL;DR**
>
> The ER model (Chen, 1976) draws entities, attributes and relationships. Chen = rectangles/ellipses/diamonds (teaching); crow's foot = attributes inside boxes and cardinality in line ends (industry, mermaid). Same model, two pictures.

10.6 Entities and the five kinds of attribute

Entities: type, instance, set

An **entity** is any object or concept in the business that you record data about and can distinguish from others like it. Three words are used loosely but mean different things:

Term	Meaning	Example
Entity type	the general kind; what the rectangle is labelled	`Employee`
Entity instance	one particular member	employee #2, Ravi Menon
Entity set	all instances that exist right now	every row in the `employee` table today

You *draw* types; the database *stores* sets.

Figure – every Chen symbol and its meaning (course diagram)

Chen notation: every symbol you need, and what each one becomes in a table

Symbol	Name	What it means, and what it becomes
	**Rectangle** entity	A thing you keep data about, like Student. Becomes a table.
	**Double rectangle** weak entity	Cannot be identified on its own. It needs an owner entity. Becomes a table with a composite primary key.
	**Ellipse** attribute	One fact about an entity, like a name or a price. Becomes one column.
	**Underlined ellipse** key attribute	Identifies one instance and never repeats. Becomes the primary key.
	**Double ellipse** multivalued attribute	Several values for one instance, like three phone numbers. Becomes a separate table, never a column.
	**Dashed ellipse** derived attribute	Calculated from other attributes, like age from a birth date. Usually becomes no column at all.
	**Ellipse with children** composite attribute	Splits into smaller parts, like an address into city and street. Becomes one column per part.
	**Diamond** relationship	A link between entities, labelled with a verb. Becomes a foreign key, or a join table if many to many.
	**Double diamond** identifying relationship	Joins a weak entity to the owner that identifies it. Becomes the foreign key inside the composite primary key.
	Double line total participation	Every instance must take part in the relationship. Becomes NOT NULL on the foreign key.

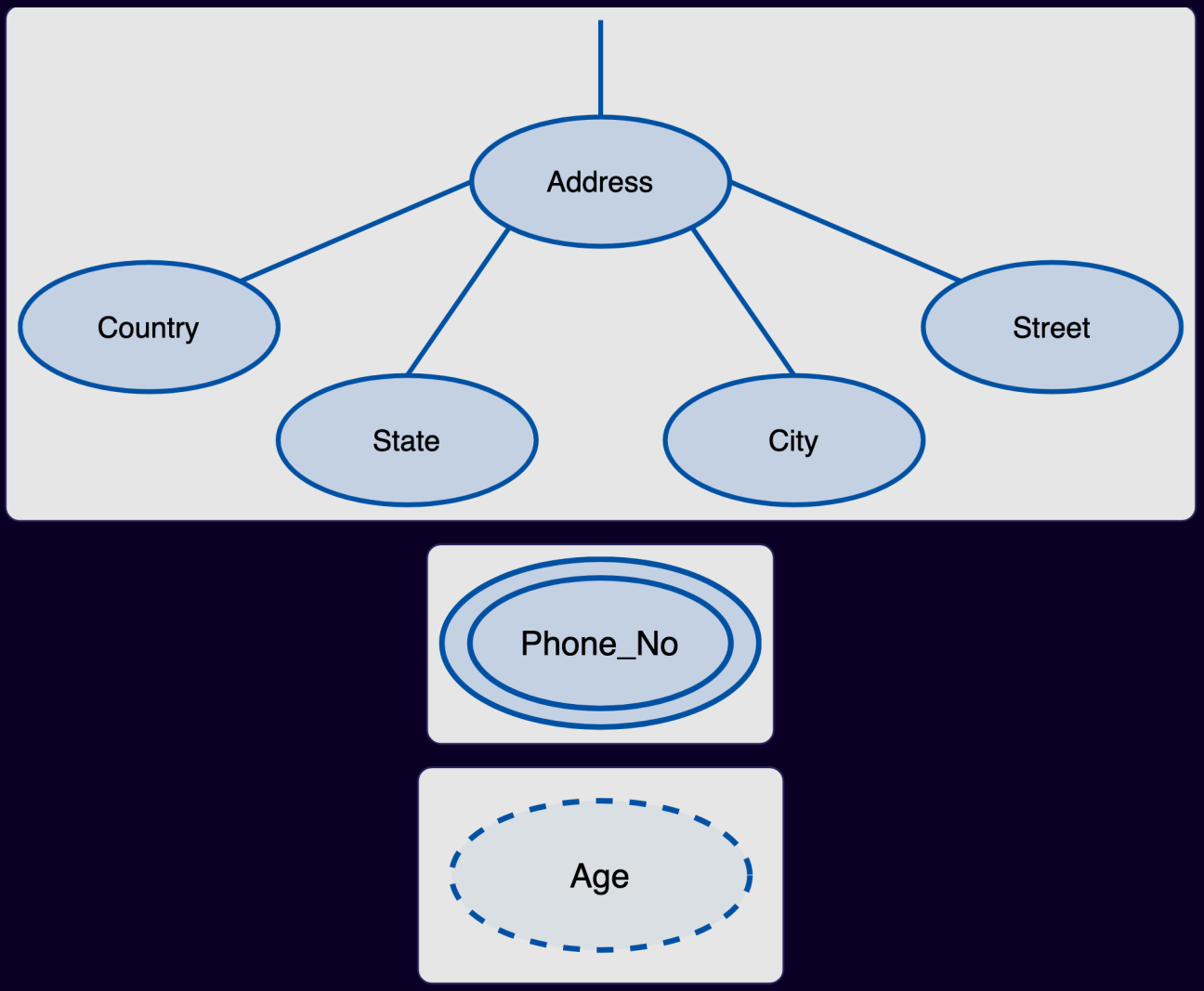
The two most confused: a double ellipse is multivalued, a dashed ellipse is derived. They are not the same thing.

The five kinds of attribute

Kind	Chen symbol	Example	Becomes in tables
Key	ellipse, name **underlined**	`emp_id`	the primary key
Simple (atomic)	plain ellipse	`birth_date`	one column
Composite	ellipse with child ellipses	`full_name` = first + middle initial + last	one column **per part**
Multivalued	**double** ellipse	`phone` (an employee may have several)	a **separate table** (owner key + value)
Derived	**dashed** ellipse	`age` (from `birth_date`)	usually **no column** – computed on read

The two most confused: **double ellipse = multivalued**, **dashed ellipse = derived**.

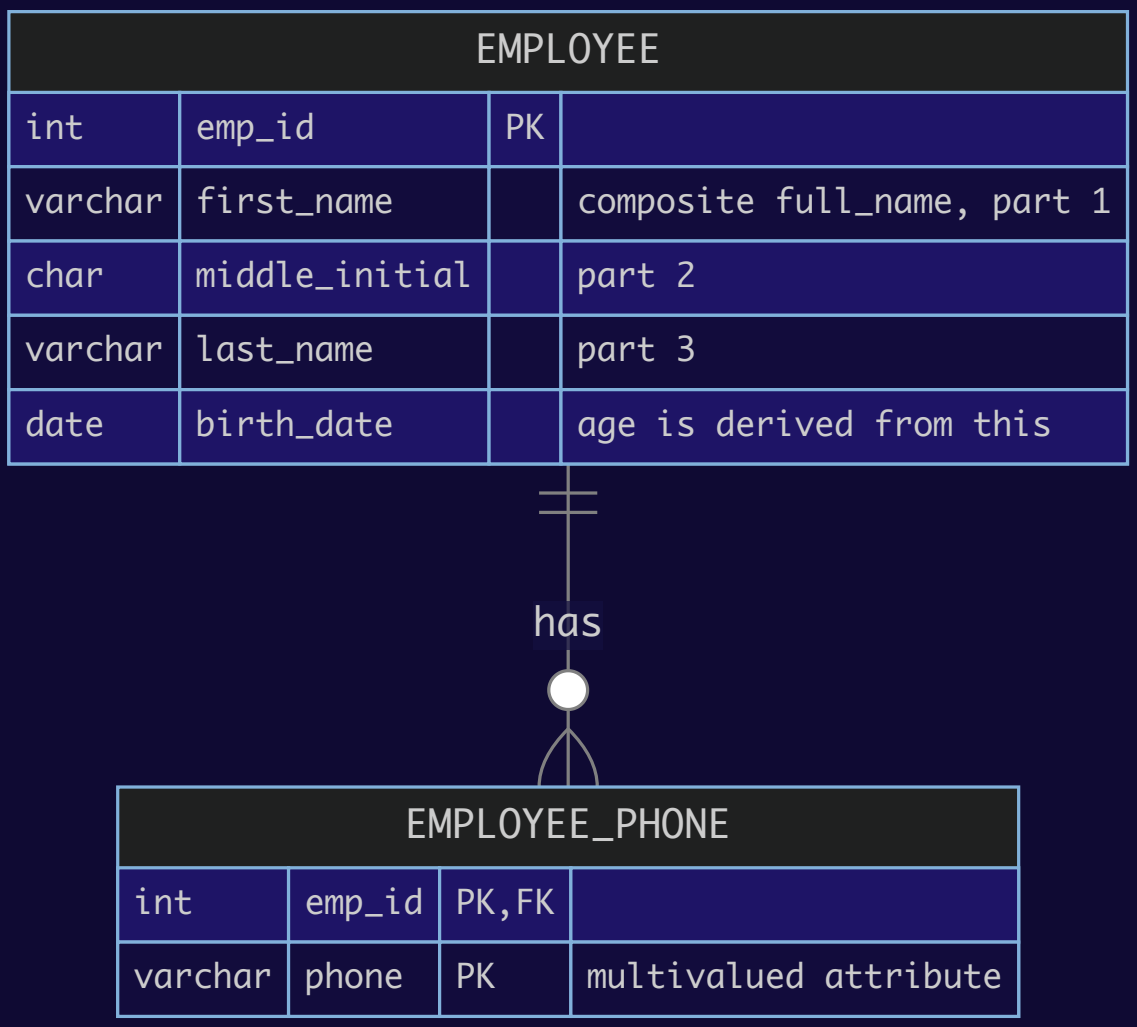
Figure – composite, multivalued and derived attributes in Chen notation (course diagrams)



Why each "becomes" rule holds:

- **Composite → split.** If the whole address sits in one column you cannot search by city. (If you *never* query the parts, one column is fine — split the day you need to.)
- **Multivalued → own table.** A relational cell holds exactly one value (§10.12), so a list cannot be a column. `phone1, phone2, phone3` is the mistake the double ellipse exists to prevent.
- **Derived → compute.** A stored `age` is wrong a year later. Store a derived value only if it is expensive to compute *and* you accept keeping it fresh — or if it must be **frozen in time** (an order total at the prices of the day of purchase is not really derivable from *today's* data).

In crow's foot there are no special shapes: the composite is already split into columns, the multivalued attribute is already a separate box, and a derived attribute is usually omitted or marked with a comment:



Self-check

1. A double ellipse means…? → **Multivalued** (e.g. phone numbers).
2. `age` next to `birth_date` – which kind, and what column? → **Derived**; no column, compute it.
3. `address` split into street/city/postcode is…? → **Composite**; one column per part.

TL;DR

Key (underlined) → PK; simple → column; composite → one column per part; multivalued (double ellipse) → separate table; derived (dashed) → computed, not stored.

10.7 Relationships: degree, cardinality and participation

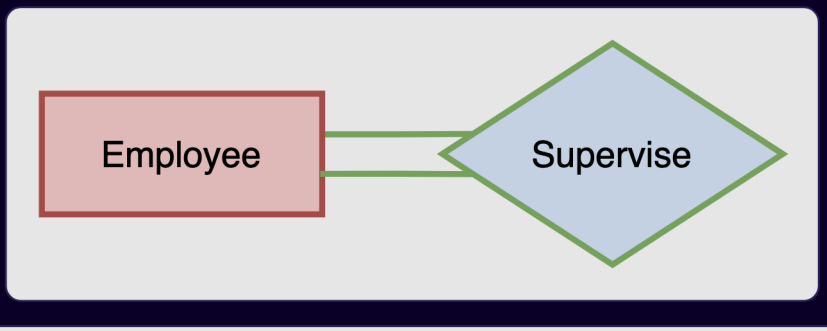
A **relationship** is an association between entities, drawn in Chen as a diamond labelled with a verb that reads well aloud ("Employee *works in* Department", not "Employee *has* Department"). As with entities, the **relationship type** is the general association you draw, and the **relationship set** is the actual pairs stored (employee 2 works in department 10, …).

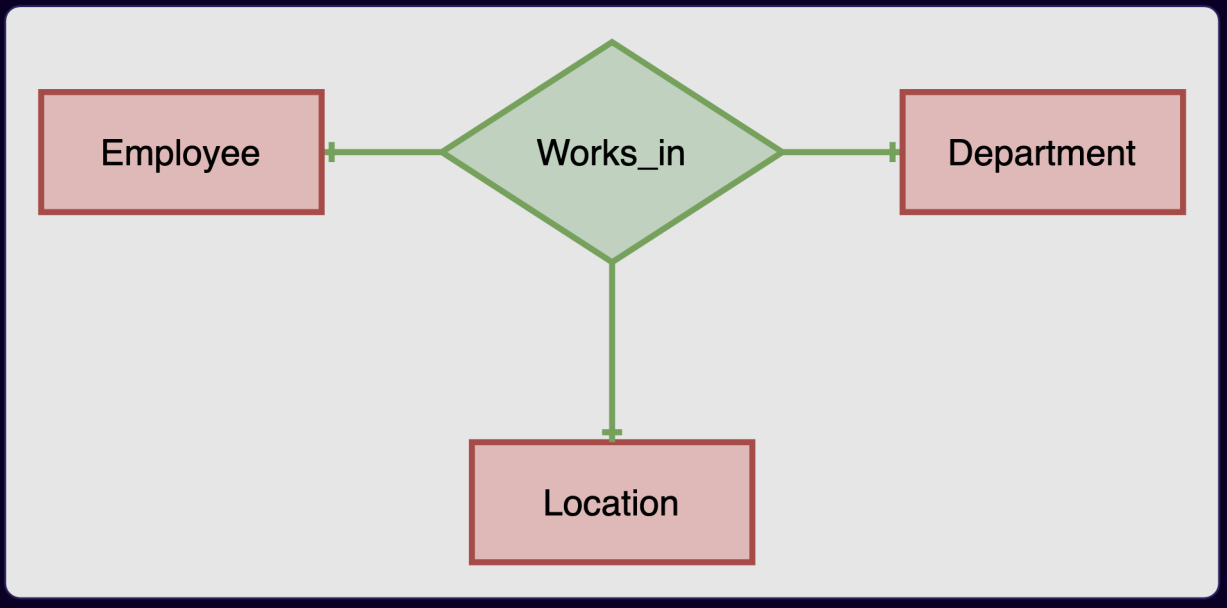
Three separate questions describe every relationship: **degree** (how many entity *types*), **cardinality** (how many *instances* on each side) and **participation** (is taking part *required*).

Degree

Degree	Name	Example	Tables
1	**Unary** (recursive)	an employee *supervises* employees	self-referencing FK: `employee.supervisor_id → employee.emp_id`
2	**Binary**	employee *works in* department	the usual case
3	**Ternary**	supplier *supplies* part *to* site	one table with three FKs, usually all three in the PK

Figure – unary and ternary relationships (course diagrams)





A ternary relationship records a fact that three binary relationships cannot: *which* combination is true. The demo in `code/04_ternary_and_weak_entity.sql` stores three supplier-part-site facts, then keeps only the binary pairs and joins them back:

```
WITH sp AS (SELECT DISTINCT supplier_id, part_id FROM supplies),
     ss AS (SELECT DISTINCT supplier_id, site_id FROM supplies)
SELECT ... FROM sp JOIN ss USING (supplier_id) ...   -- rebuild from pairs
```

Output:

```
--- the ternary fact: who supplies what, where
 supplier | part  | city
----------+-------+-------
 Acme     | bolt  | Leeds
 Acme     | panel | Pune
 Bolt Co  | bolt  | Pune
(3 rows)

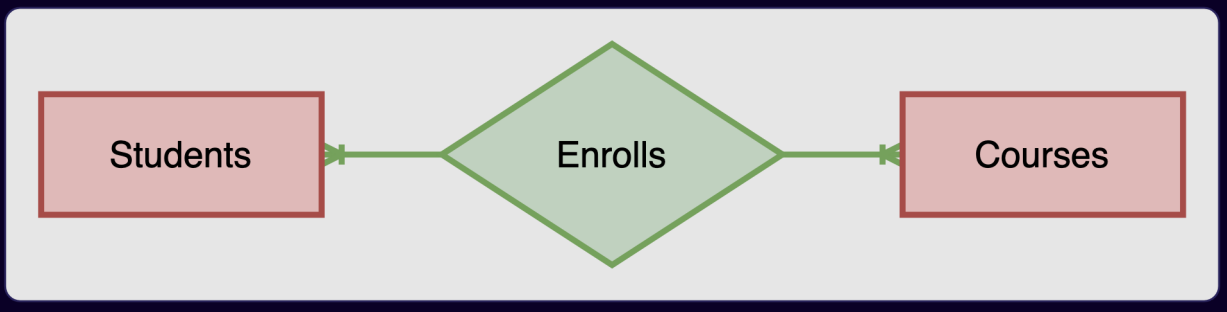
--- keep only binary pairs (supplier-part, supplier-site) and join them back:
 supplier | part  | city  | really_true
----------+-------+-------+-------------
 Acme     | bolt  | Leeds | t
 Acme     | bolt  | Pune  | f
 Acme     | panel | Leeds | f
 Acme     | panel | Pune  | t
 Bolt Co  | bolt  | Pune  | t
(5 rows)
```

From the pairs alone you cannot tell whether Acme sends bolts to Pune. Ternary relationships are rare, though — before drawing one, check the fact truly needs all three at once (Chapter 11's 5NF, §11.13, is the formal version of this question).

Cardinality (mapping cardinality)

Cardinality	Meaning	Example
1:1	each side links to at most one of the other	employee ↔ payroll record
1:N	one on the left, many on the right	a department employs many employees
N:1	1:N viewed from the opposite side	many employees work in one department
M:N	many on both sides	employees work on many projects; a project has many employees

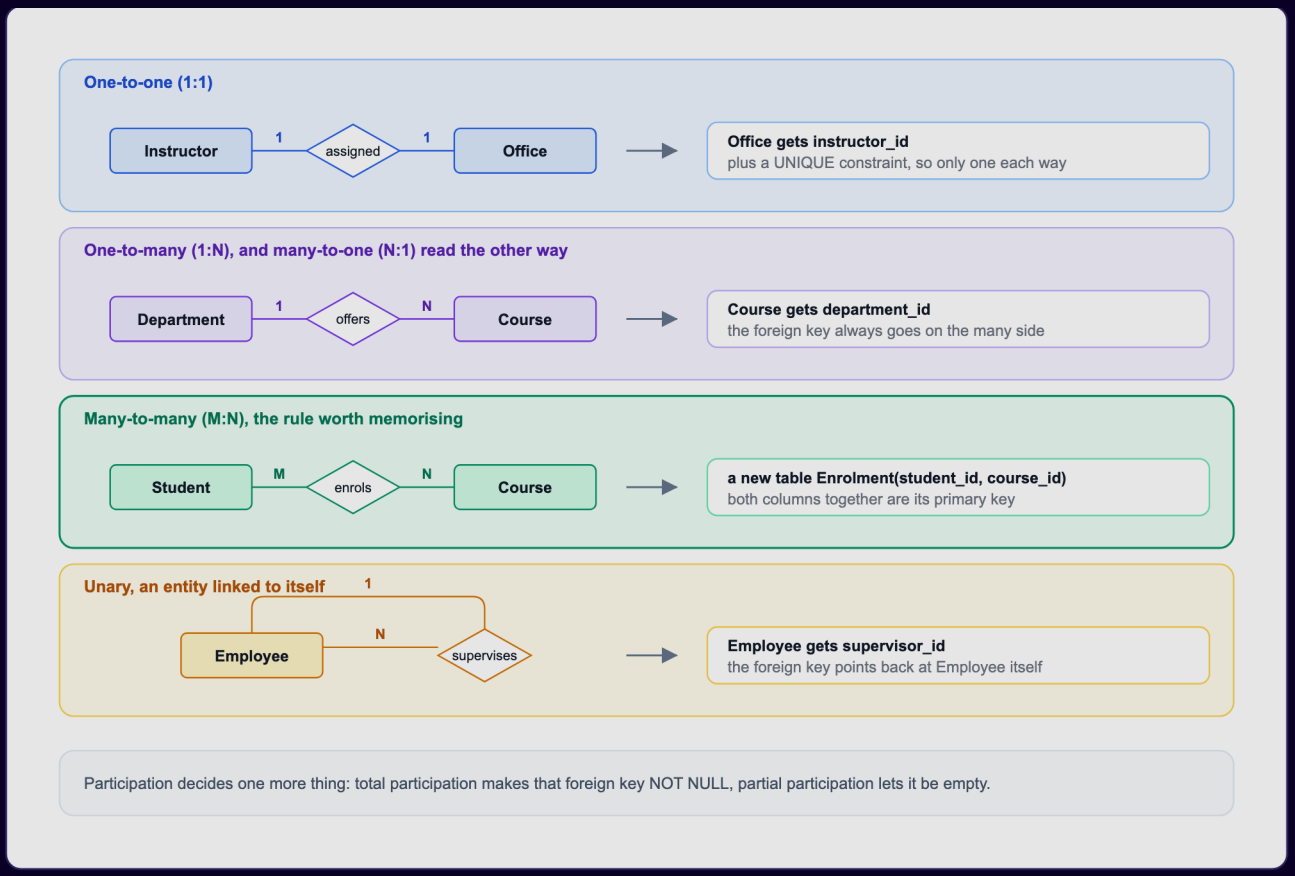
Figure — many-to-many in Chen notation (course diagram)



1:N and N:1 are one relationship described from opposite ends; both names are correct.

How each cardinality becomes tables

Figure — cardinality to foreign keys (course diagram)



Cardinality	Rule	Why
1:N / N:1	FK on the **many** side (`employee.dept_id`)	the "one" side would need a list in a cell
M:N	a new **junction table** (also *join*, *bridge* or *associative* table) holding both FKs, which together form its PK (`works_on(emp_id, project_id)`)	there is no single side to put it on
1:1	FK on **either** side + `UNIQUE` ; prefer the side with total participation so it can be `NOT NULL`	without `UNIQUE` it silently becomes 1:N
Unary	FK to the same table	

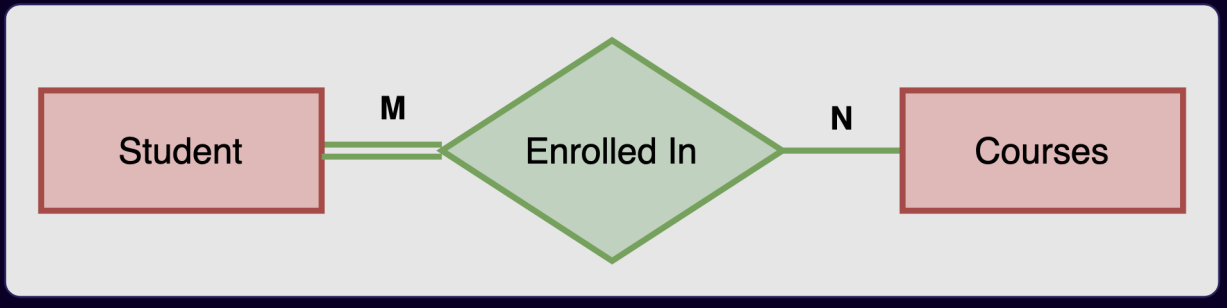
Memorise this one: **every M:N link in a diagram costs three tables in SQL.**

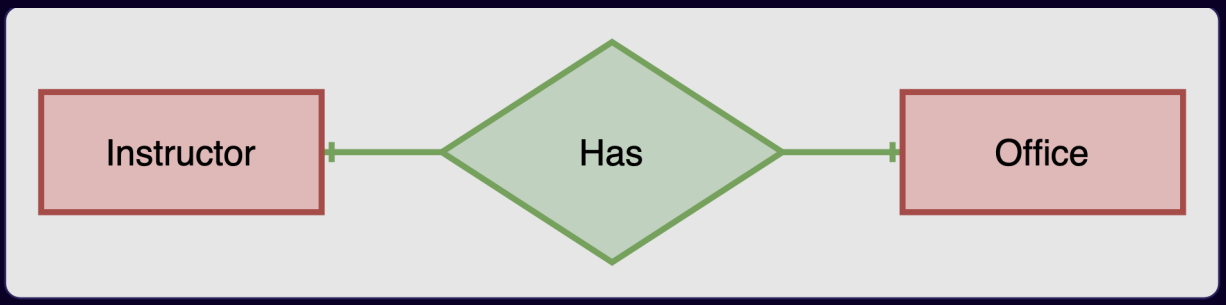
Participation

Participation says whether every instance *must* take part.

	Chen drawing	Meaning	Becomes
Total (mandatory)	double line	every employee must work in a department	FK `NOT NULL`
Partial (optional)	single line	an employee may have no supervisor	FK allows `NULL`

Figure – total (double line) and partial (single line) participation (course diagrams)





Skipping participation is easy and expensive: it decides whether a column can be empty, and that decision affects every query (outer vs inner joins, `IS NULL` checks).

The (min, max) notation

Design tools often label each end with a pair **(min, max)** – the fewest and most times one instance can take part:

Pair	Meaning	Participation	Crow's foot
`(0,1)`	at most once, maybe never	partial	`o|`
`(1,1)`	exactly once	total	`||`
`(0,N)`	any number, including none	partial	`o{`
`(1,N)`	at least once	total	`|{`

The minimum is the participation; the maximum is the cardinality. That is why tools prefer the pair: one label says both.

Careful: in Chen's `(min,max)` style the pair is usually written next to the entity it describes ("each employee works in (1,1) departments"), which is the *opposite* end from where crow's foot draws its symbol. Always check a diagram's legend.

In the interview

> **30-second answer:** "Degree counts the entity types involved – one (unary), two (binary) or three (ternary). Cardinality is how many instances link: 1:1, 1:N or M:N. Participation is whether taking part is mandatory. 1:N puts the FK on the many side; M:N needs a junction table; 1:1 is an FK plus UNIQUE; total participation makes the FK NOT NULL."

- *Where does the FK go in a 1:N?* → Many side. *Why not the one side?* → It would need a list in one cell, which violates 1NF.
- *How do you enforce 1:1 in SQL?* → FK + `UNIQUE` on it (or share the same PK in both tables).
- *Can you enforce "every department has at least one employee" with a plain FK?* → No; an FK constrains the child side. You need a deferred constraint trigger or application logic.

TL;DR

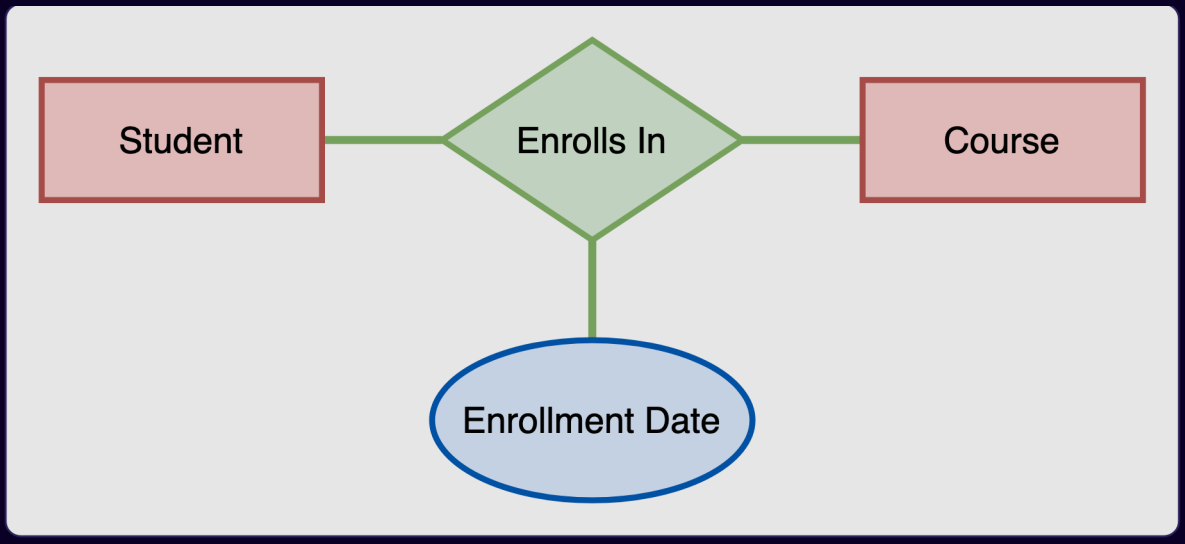
Degree = number of entity types; cardinality = max instances per side; participation = min (mandatory or not). 1:N → FK on many side; M:N → junction table; 1:1 → FK + UNIQUE; unary → self-FK; total → NOT NULL.

10.8 Attributes of relationships

What it is

Some facts describe the **link**, not either entity. The hours an employee spends on a project depend on *both* the employee and the project. In Chen notation such an attribute hangs off the diamond.

Figure – an attribute on a relationship (course diagram)



The test: *would you need to know both entities to know the value?*

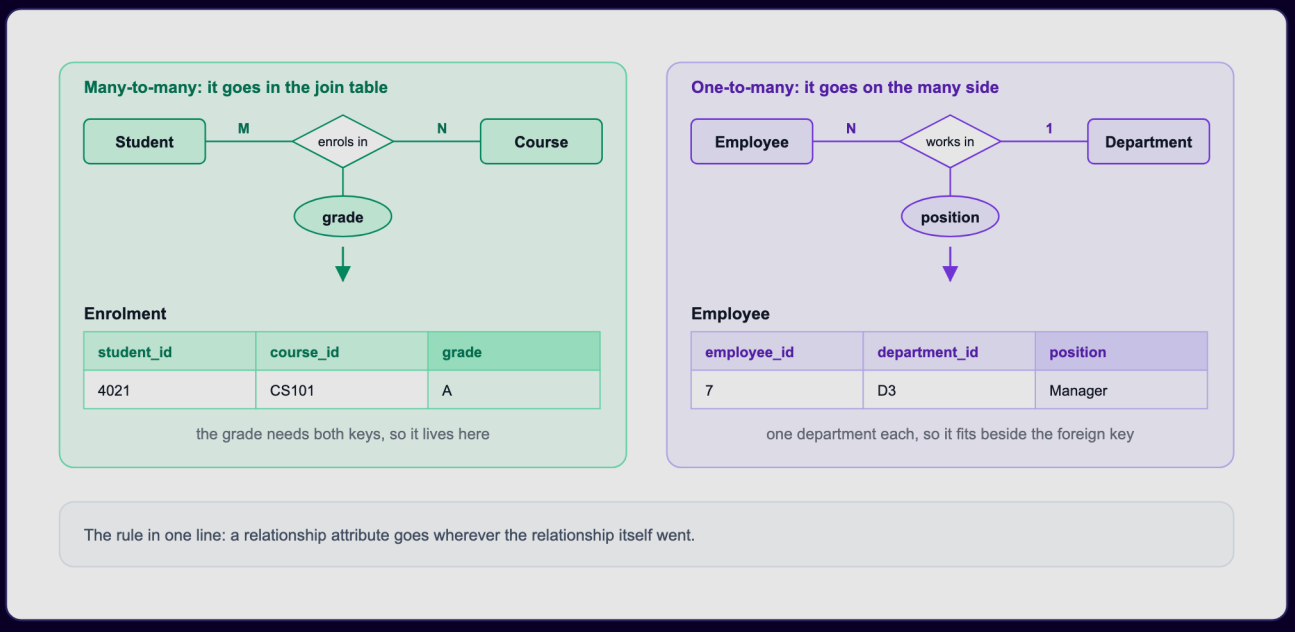
Attribute	Needs	Belongs on
`weekly_hours`	employee **and** project	the relationship *works on*
`start_date` of an assignment	employee **and** project	the relationship
`title`	project only	Project
`last_name`	employee only	Employee

Where it lands in tables

Put the attribute wherever the relationship itself ended up:

- **M:N** → a column in the junction table: `works_on(emp_id, project_id, weekly_hours)`.
- **1:N** → the many side, beside the FK (if an employee works in exactly one department, `role_in_dept` sits on `employee` next to `dept_id`).
- **1:1** → wherever the FK went.

Figure — placement depends on cardinality (course diagram)



Putting it on an entity forces a false rule: `weekly_hours` on `employee` allows only one number per employee, however many projects they work on.

When a relationship should become an entity

When a link collects many facts (a rental has out time, due time, return time, fee), promote it to an entity. The tables come out identical; the diagram just gains a box for a noun people already use. **Test:** if the business has a noun for the link ("rental", "loan", "enrolment", "booking"), make it an entity. That is why `rental` in the bike shop is an entity, not a diamond between Customer and Bike.

TL;DR

If a fact needs both ends of a link, it is a relationship attribute; it lands in the junction table (M:N) or the many side (1:N). A link with its own name and many facts becomes an entity.

10.9 Weak entities

What it is

A **weak entity** has nothing of its own that singles it out. "Room 101" is ambiguous – many buildings have one. Only *(Main building, room 101)* identifies it. The entity it depends on is the **owner** (or identifying / strong entity).

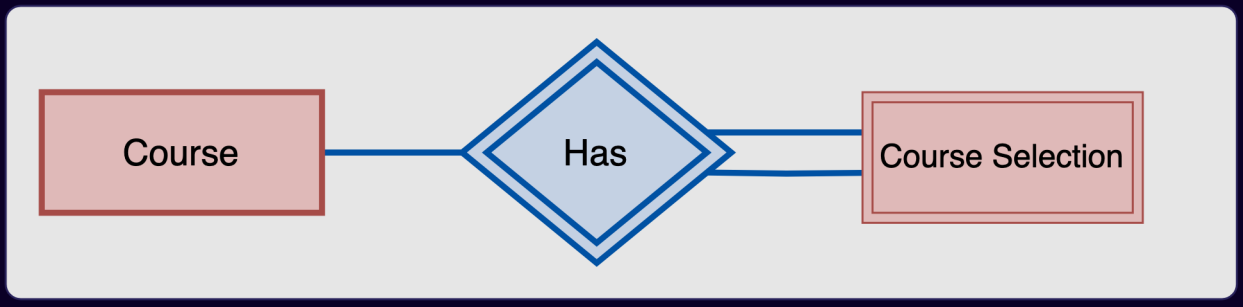
Four properties:

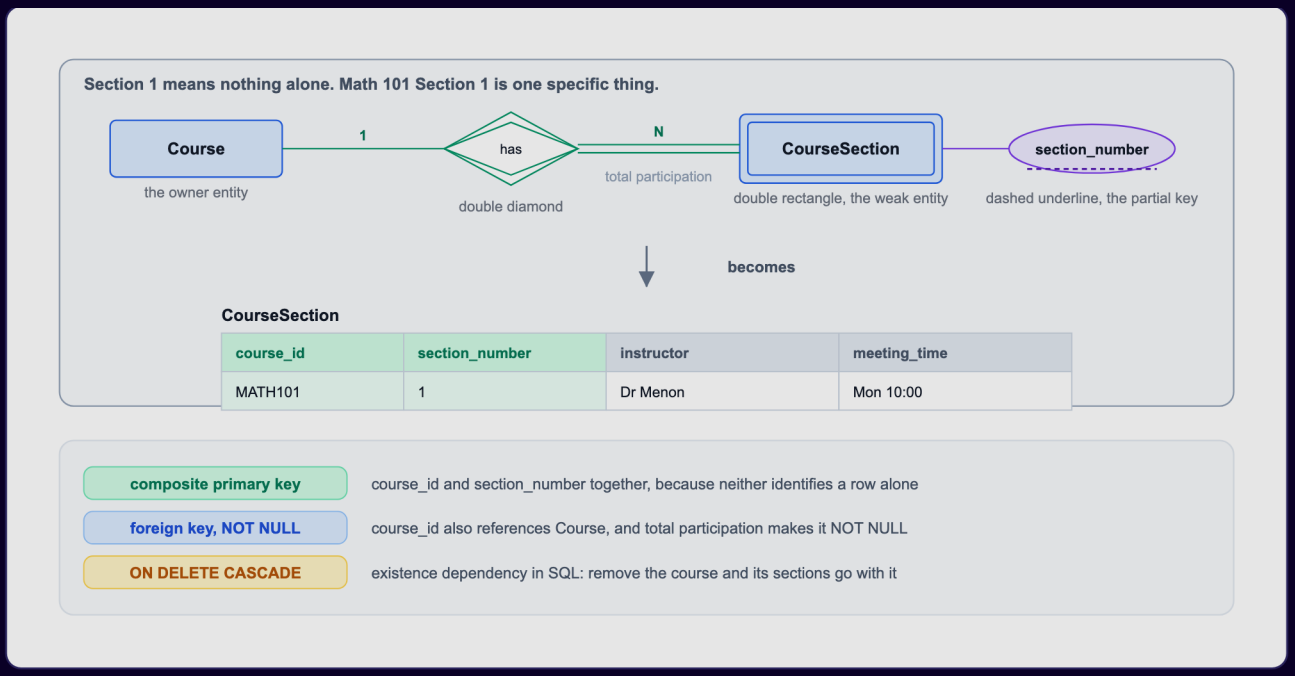
1. **No key of its own** – nothing inside it is unique across all instances.
2. **A partial key** (also called a **discriminator**) – unique *within one owner* (`room_no`).
3. **Existence dependency** – delete the building and its rooms mean nothing.
4. **Total participation in the identifying relationship** – no room belongs to no building.

How it is drawn

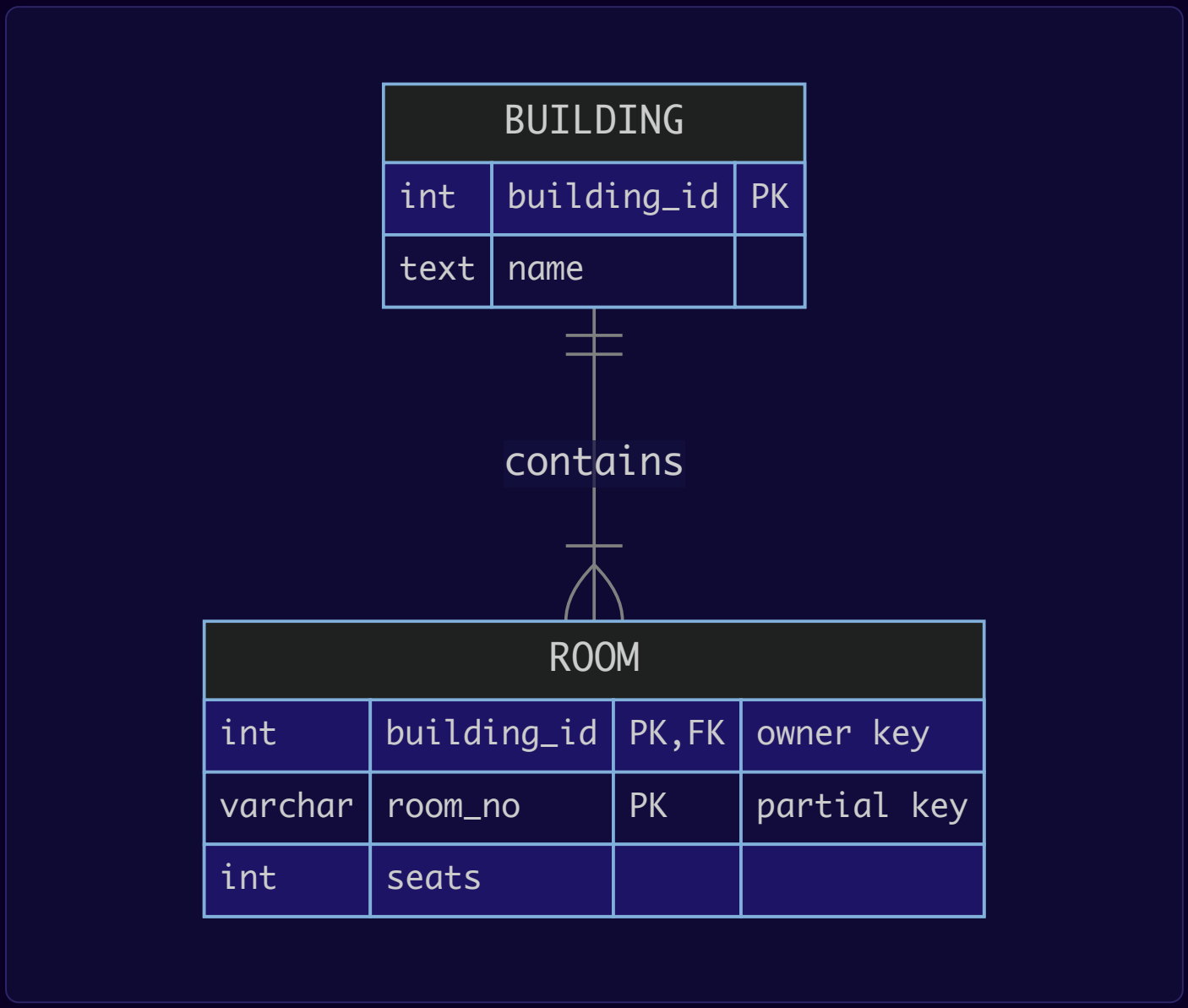
Chen symbol	Meaning
double rectangle	the weak entity
double diamond	the **identifying relationship**
dashed underline	the partial key
double line (weak side)	total participation

Figure – a weak entity in Chen notation, and its table (course diagrams)





In crow's foot (mermaid), a weak entity is shown by an **identifying (solid) line** and a PK that includes the owner's key:



What it becomes in SQL — two valid options

```
-- Option A: composite key = owner key + partial key
CREATE TABLE room_a (
  building_id int NOT NULL REFERENCES building ON DELETE CASCADE,
  room_no     varchar(6) NOT NULL,                -- partial key (discriminator)
  seats       int,
  PRIMARY KEY (building_id, room_no)
);
-- Option B: surrogate key + UNIQUE on (owner key, partial key)
CREATE TABLE room_b (
  room_id     int GENERATED ALWAYS AS IDENTITY PRIMARY KEY,
  building_id int NOT NULL REFERENCES building ON DELETE CASCADE,
  room_no     varchar(6) NOT NULL,
  seats       int,
  UNIQUE (building_id, room_no)                   -- without this, duplicates slip in
);
```

Output (both options refuse a duplicate room, and cascade when the owner goes):

```
--- both options refuse a second room 101 in building 1
NOTICE:  room_a: duplicate key value violates unique constraint "room_a_pkey"
NOTICE:  room_b: duplicate key value violates unique constraint "room_b_building_id_room_no_key"
--- existence dependency: delete the Annex, its rooms go too
 room_a_rows | room_b_rows
-------------+-------------
           1 |           1
(1 row)
```

	Composite PK (A)	Surrogate PK (B)
Enforces "no duplicate partial key per owner"	automatically	only with the extra `UNIQUE` (easy to forget)
Referencing it from other tables	two columns	one column
Key width copied into child FKs/indexes	wider	narrow

Common examples: order → order line (`(order_id, line_no)`), building → room, invoice → invoice line. **Weak or not is a design decision:** bank transactions numbered per account are weak; with a global transaction id they are strong. A reasonable default is option B *with* the unique constraint.

Self-check

1. What is a partial key? → An attribute unique only within one owner (e.g. `line_no` within an order).
2. Which SQL clause expresses existence dependency? → `ON DELETE CASCADE` on the owner FK.
3. Why is the owner FK `NOT NULL`? → Participation in the identifying relationship is total.

TL;DR

Weak entity = identified only together with its owner. PK = owner key + partial key (or surrogate + `UNIQUE(owner, partial)`), owner FK `NOT NULL` and `ON DELETE CASCADE`. Chen: double rectangle, double diamond, dashed underline.

10.10 Worked example — an employee-management ER diagram

The brief

A company wants to:

1. Record each employee: name, date of birth, one or more phone numbers, and the department they belong to (every employee has exactly one department).

2. Keep one payroll record per employee (monthly salary, cash advance, tax); no payroll record is shared by two employees. Net pay is salary − advance − tax.
3. Record who supervises whom (the CEO has no supervisor).
4. Record which projects employees work on and for how many hours a week (many-to-many).
5. Record each employee's dependants (children, spouse) for insurance; a dependant is identified by name *within* an employee.

Step 1 – entities (nouns)

Employee, Department, Payroll, Project, Dependant. ("Record", "information" and "number" are words about data, not things.)

Step 2 – attributes, classified

Entity	Attribute	Kind	Reason
Employee	`emp_id`	key	issued once, never repeats
	`full_name`	composite	first name, middle initial, last name
	`birth_date`	simple	one value
	`phone`	**multivalued**	"one or more"
	`age`	**derived**	from `birth_date`
Payroll	`payroll_id`	key	
	`monthly_salary`, `cash_advance`, `tax`	simple, **stored**	typed in by a person – nothing computes them
	`net_pay`	**derived**	salary − advance − tax
Department	`dept_id` (key), `dept_name`		
Project	`project_id` (key), `title`		
Dependant	`dep_name`	**partial key**	unique only within one employee
	`relationship`	simple	

The recurring trap is salary vs net pay: **if someone types the value in, it is stored; if you can compute it from stored attributes, it is derived.**

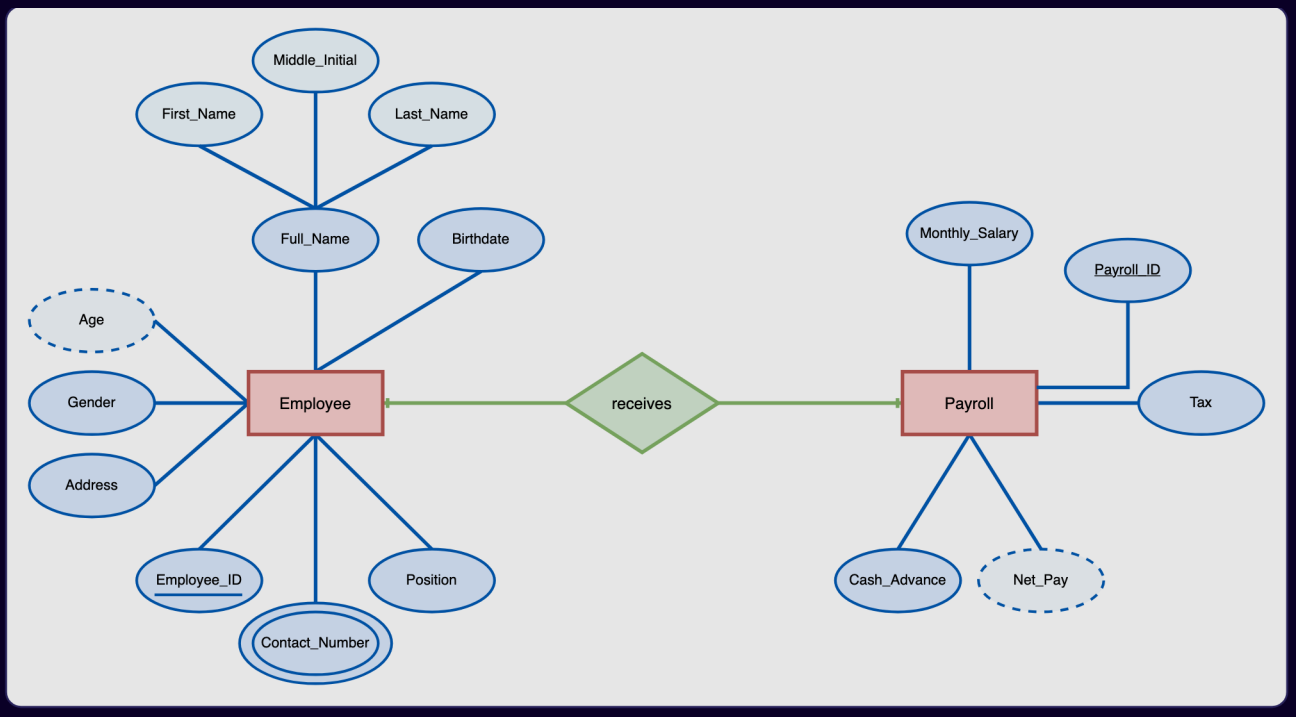
Steps 3–4 – relationships with degree, cardinality and participation

Relationship	Degree	Cardinality	Participation
Employee *works in* Department	binary	N:1	employee total (brief says "exactly one")
Employee *is paid through* Payroll	binary	1:1	both total
Employee *supervises* Employee	unary	1:N	partial (CEO has none)
Employee *works on* Project, attribute `weekly_hours`	binary	M:N	partial
Employee *has* Dependant (identifying)	binary	1:N	dependant total

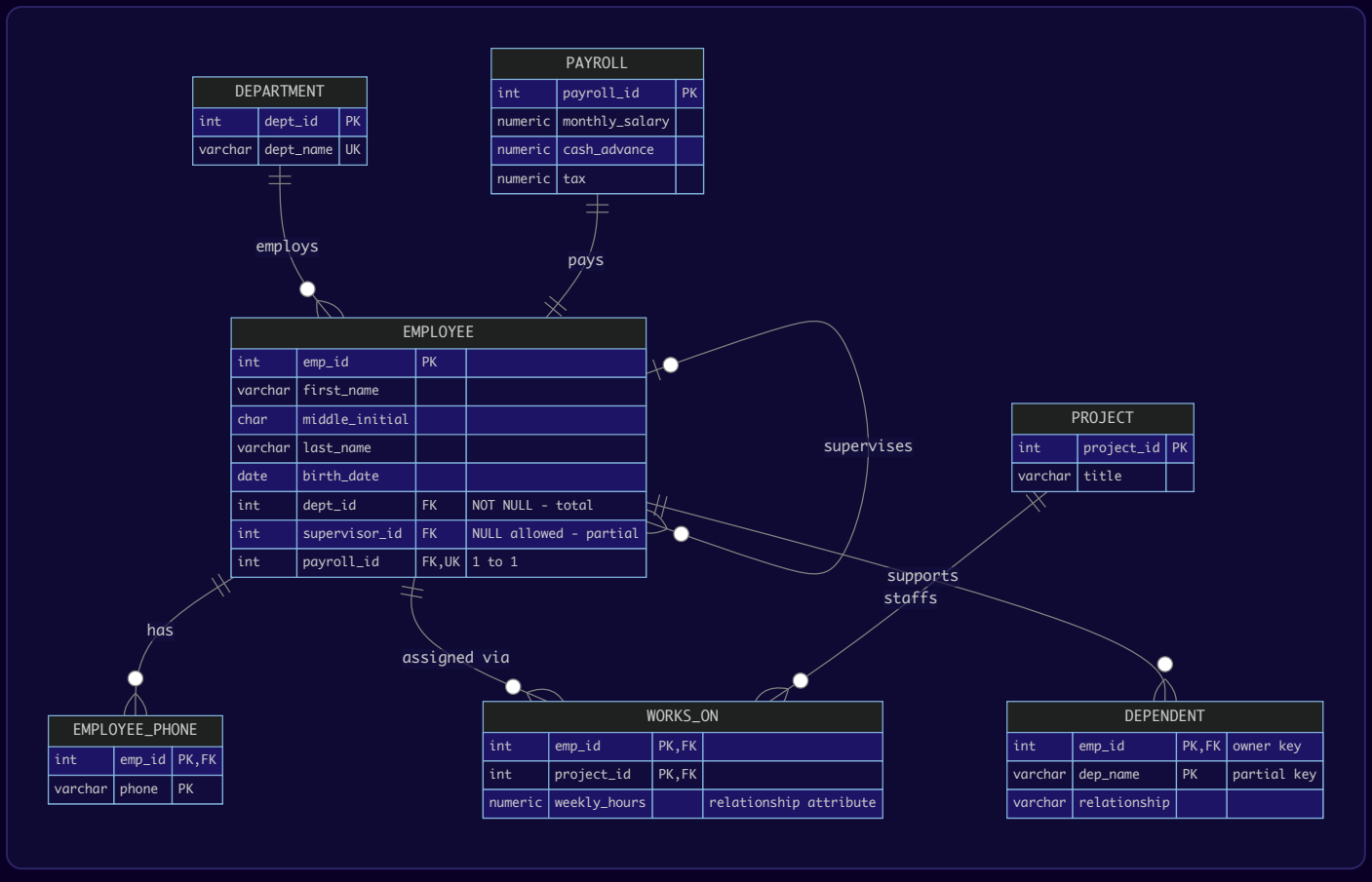
Step 5 – the diagram

The course's Chen diagram for the core of this system (Employee + Payroll, with composite, multivalued and derived attributes) shows every special symbol at once:

Figure – Employee and Payroll in Chen notation: underlined keys, composite Full_Name, double-ellipse Contact_Number, dashed Age and Net_Pay (course diagram)



The full design in crow's-foot notation:



Read it back as sentences – if one sounds wrong, the diagram is wrong: "Each employee works in exactly one department; a department employs zero or more employees (the brief does not require every department to have staff). Each employee has exactly one payroll record and vice versa. An employee may supervise several employees and has at most one supervisor…"

Design check: does Payroll deserve its own table?

A 1:1 with total participation on **both** sides usually describes one thing stored in two places. Reasons to keep two tables anyway:

- **Access control** – salaries can be granted to HR only (`GRANT SELECT ON payroll TO hr`; see Chapter 14).

- **Row width** – the frequently read `employee` row stays narrow.
- **Optional data** – if many employees had no payroll row, a separate table stores nothing for them instead of several `NULL`s.

Reasons to merge: no join, and no way to have an employee without payroll. Either answer is acceptable in an interview **if you notice the question and justify your choice.** Here we keep them separate for access control. §10.15 converts this diagram to tables and runs it.

TL;DR

Nouns → entities; classify every attribute (key/simple/composite/multivalued/derived); settle degree, cardinality and participation separately for each verb; read the diagram back as sentences; a 1:1 with total participation both ways should always prompt "one table or two?".

10.11 The relational model

What it is

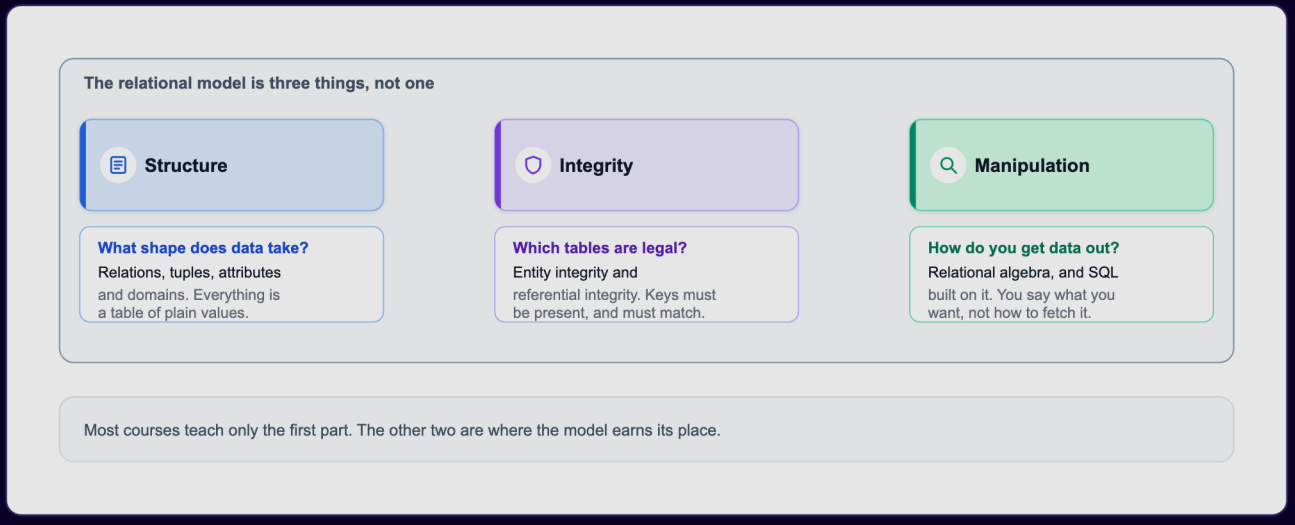
The ER diagram is a drawing; a database stores **relations** (tables). The **relational model**, published by **Edgar F. Codd in 1970**, says: store all data as tables of values, and let programs *describe* the data they want while the system works out how to fetch it.

Before it, hierarchical and network databases made programs walk stored paths of pointers (employee record → pointer → department record). Reorganize the file and every program walking that path broke.

The three parts of the model

Part	Question it answers	Content
Structure	What shape is the data?	Only relations: a name, named columns, rows of single values. No nested records, arrays or pointers.
Integrity	Which tables are legal?	Keys and constraints declared once on the table; the DBMS refuses any change that breaks them.
Manipulation	How do I get data out?	Declarative queries (SQL), built on **relational algebra**: operations (select, project, join, union, difference …) that take relations and return a relation.

Figure – structure, integrity, manipulation (course diagram)



Links are values, not pointers

`employee.dept_id = 10` links to the department whose `dept_id` is 10 – the shared *value* is the whole link. Consequences:

- The link survives copying the table to another server, reloading in a different order, or rebuilding indexes.
- The DBMS can **check** the link (a foreign key refuses `dept_id = 99` if no department 99 exists). A raw pointer cannot be checked like that.

What you get

- **One rule reaches every program** – constraints live with the data.
- **Physical data independence** – queries name *what*, not *how*, so indexes and storage can change without editing queries.
- **Some logical data independence** – adding a column or hiding a split behind a view does not break existing queries. It is *not* total: renaming a column or shrinking its type still breaks the programs that use it.

What it does not promise

- **Nothing about storage** – files, pages and indexes belong to the storage engine (Chapter 12).
- **Joins are not free** – matching values costs work that grows with table size.
- **A table is not always an entity** – tables also come from M:N relationships (`works_on`) and multivalued attributes (`employee_phone`).

> **TL;DR**
>
> Codd (1970): everything is a relation of single values; integrity rules are declared on tables; queries are declarative. Rows link by shared values, which can be checked and survive reorganization.

10.12 Relations, tuples, attributes – the precise vocabulary

The core words

Formal term	SQL term	Older file term	Meaning
relation	table	file	named set of rows with fixed named columns
tuple	row	record	one value for each attribute
attribute	column	field	a named column
domain	data type + constraints	field type	the set of allowed values for an attribute
degree (arity)	number of columns	number of fields	a property of the schema
cardinality	number of rows	number of records	a property of the current data

Figure – anatomy of a relation (course diagram)



- **Domain** is what you *mean*, which is more than a type: `int` is a type; "integers 1–500" is the domain you meant for room capacity, enforced with `CHECK`.
- **Schema vs instance.** The **relation schema** is the design – `room(room_id, code, capacity)` – and rarely changes. The **relation instance** is the set of rows at this moment and changes with every insert. A key belongs to the *schema*, so it has to be true for any data the table could ever legally contain – the current rows prove nothing.
- **Two meanings of "cardinality".** In §10.7 it meant how many instances link (1:N); here it means a row count. Both are standard; context tells you which.

Five properties of every relation

1. **One value per cell** (atomic) – no lists, no nested records. This is why multivalued attributes need their own table, and it is the heart of 1NF (§11.7).
2. **Rows have no inherent order** – a relation is a set, so if you need sorted output you must ask for it with `ORDER BY`.
3. **Columns have no inherent order either** – you refer to them by name. (Real SQL tables do remember the order columns were declared in, so `SELECT *` always lists them the same way; still, list the columns you want explicitly.)
4. **Attribute names are unique within a relation.**
5. **No duplicate tuples** – a set has no duplicates. *Here SQL differs:* a SQL table accepts identical rows unless a `PRIMARY KEY` or `UNIQUE` forbids them. Declaring a key closes the gap.

NULL

`NULL` marks a **missing** value: either *unknown* (grade not yet computed) or *not applicable* (no middle name). It is not zero and not the empty string. SQL uses **three-valued logic**: comparing anything with `NULL` gives *unknown*, and `WHERE` keeps only rows where the condition is *true* (Chapter 2 covers this in depth). From `code/03_keys_and_integrity.sql`:

```
SELECT (SELECT count(*) FROM lecturer WHERE room_id = NULL)  AS eq_null,
       (SELECT count(*) FROM lecturer WHERE room_id IS NULL) AS is_null,
       count(room_id) AS count_col, count(*) AS count_star
FROM lecturer;
```

Output:

```
 eq_null | is_null | count_col | count_star
---------+---------+-----------+------------
       0 |       2 |         1 |          3
(1 row)
```

`= NULL` matches nothing, `IS NULL` works, `count(col)` skips nulls while `count(*)` counts rows. So whenever a column is nullable, each query touching it must decide how missing values are treated.

Self-check

1. `student(roll_no, name, cgpa, dept)` holds 8,000 rows. Degree? Cardinality? → **4** and **8,000**.
2. Does a SQL table forbid duplicate rows by default? → **No** — only a key or `UNIQUE` does.
3. Why can't you prove `{name}` is a key by looking at the rows? → Keys are schema properties; rows can only *disprove* one (two equal names).

TL;DR

Relation = table, tuple = row, attribute = column, domain = allowed values; degree = #columns (schema), cardinality = #rows (instance). Cells are atomic, order is meaningless, formal relations have no duplicates (SQL tables do unless keyed). `NULL` = missing; test with `IS NULL`.

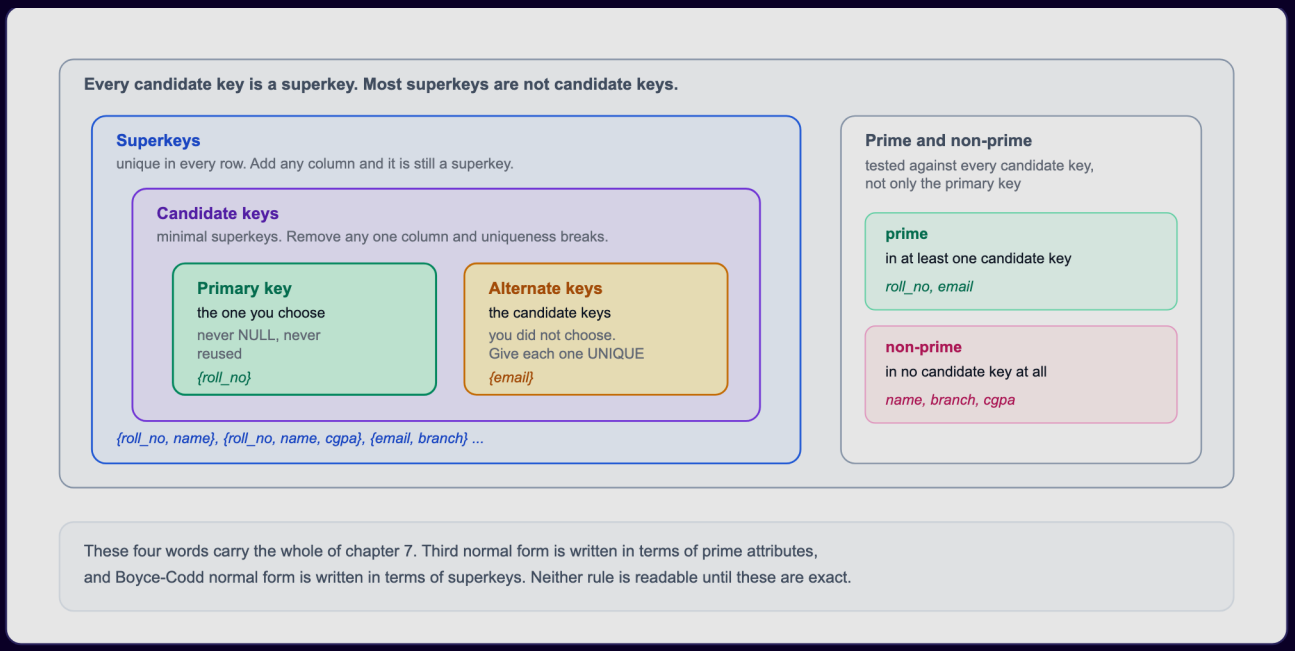
10.13 Keys in relational databases

Two identical-looking rows — same name, department and year — and a support ticket asking to change "that student". Without something that tells rows apart, the request has no answer. **Keys** make identity exist. Chapter 11 states its rules with exactly these definitions, so precision matters.

Running example: `lecturer(lecturer_id, email, name, room_id)`, where ids are issued once and emails are unique.

Key	Definition	Example
Superkey	a set of attributes that can **never** repeat in two rows (in any legal instance)	`{lecturer_id}`, `{email}`, `{lecturer_id, name}`, all four columns …
Candidate key	a **minimal** superkey — remove any attribute and it stops being unique	`{lecturer_id}`, `{email}`
Primary key	the one candidate key you *choose*; unique and never `NULL`	`lecturer_id`
Alternate key	any candidate key other than the chosen primary one — declare it `UNIQUE`	`email`
Composite key	any key with 2+ attributes (a shape, not a separate kind)	`booking(room_id, day, slot)`
Foreign key	attributes whose values must match a key in a (possibly the same) table, or be `NULL`	`lecturer.room_id → room.room_id`
Natural key	made of real-world data	email, ISBN, frame number
Surrogate key	system-generated, no business meaning	identity integer, UUID

Figure — superkeys ⊇ candidate keys ⊇ primary key, with prime and non-prime attributes (course diagram)



Key facts to be exact about:

- **A superkey stays a superkey when you add columns to it**, so there are many of them; candidate keys are the ones with nothing spare. Minimality is about *removability*, not size – a 3-column candidate key is fine if none can go.
- **All candidate keys are superkeys, but the reverse is rarely true.**
- **Prime attribute** = appears in *some* candidate key (any of them, not only the chosen primary key). **Non-prime** = belongs to none. In `lecturer`, `lecturer_id` and `email` are prime; `name` and `room_id` are non-prime. 3NF is defined with these words (§11.9).
- **Composite example.** `enrolment(student_id, course_id, term, grade)`: students may retake a course another term, so only `{student_id, course_id, term}` identifies a row, and dropping any of the three breaks it.
- **Foreign keys:** may be `NULL` (no link yet – that is not a violation); may reference any `PRIMARY KEY` or `UNIQUE` column set; may reference their own table (`employee.supervisor_id`), which is how a unary relationship becomes a column.
- **Surrogate vs natural:** surrogates are narrow and never change; natural keys are readable and sometimes save a join, but change when the business changes (a new roll-number format means updating every FK). **Default: surrogate PK + `UNIQUE` natural key** – the `customer` table in `00_schema.sql` does exactly that.

In the interview

> **30-second answer:** "A superkey uniquely identifies rows; a candidate key is a minimal superkey; the primary key is the candidate I pick – unique and not null; the other candidates are alternate keys and get UNIQUE constraints. A foreign key references a primary or unique key and may be null. My default is a generated surrogate PK, with the natural key kept unique."

- *Is `{id, name}` a candidate key?* → A superkey, not a candidate key: `name` can be dropped.
- *UUID vs bigint surrogate?* → UUIDs can be generated anywhere without coordination but are 16 bytes vs 8 and random UUIDs scatter B-tree inserts; time-ordered UUIDs (v7) reduce that.
- *Is an attribute of an alternate key prime?* → Yes – prime means "in any candidate key".

TL;DR

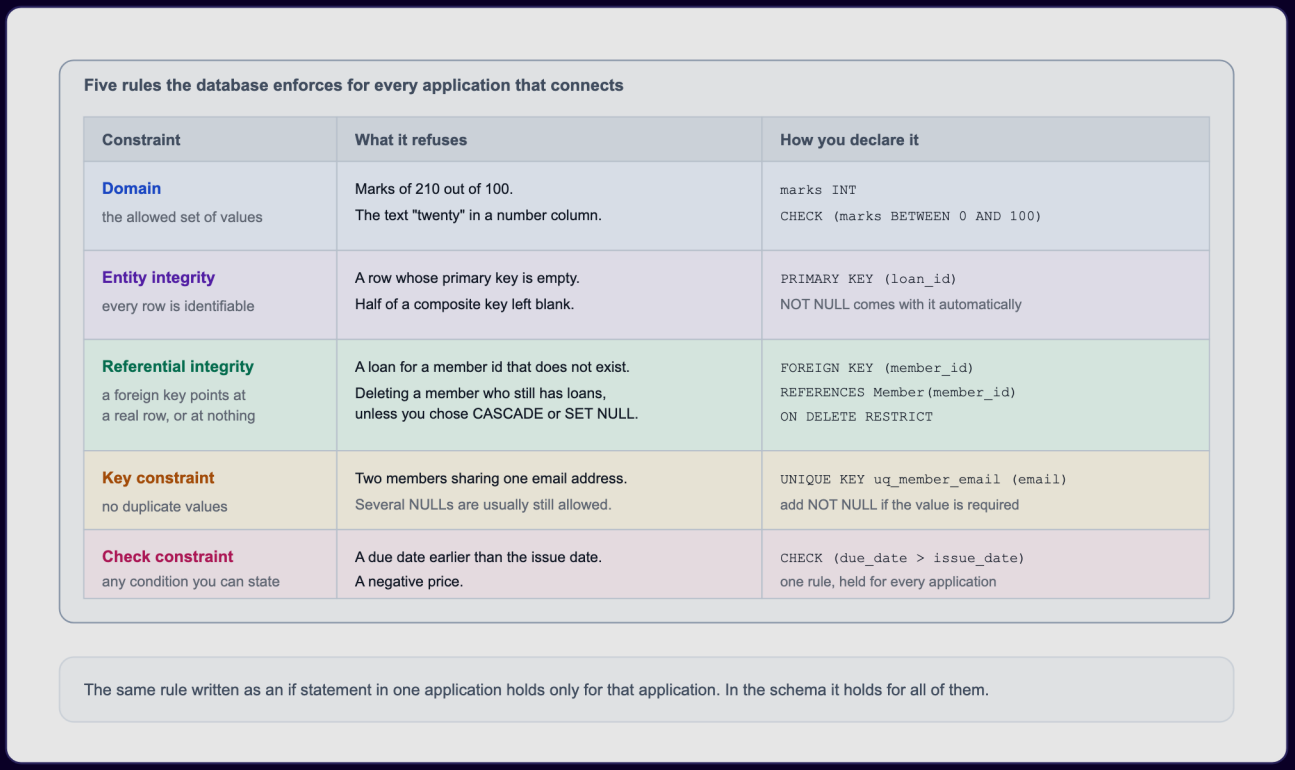
Superkey (unique) ⊇ candidate key (minimal) ⊇ primary key (chosen, NOT NULL); other candidates = alternate keys (UNIQUE). Prime = in some candidate key. FKs match a PK/UNIQUE or are NULL. Surrogate PK + unique natural key is the safe default.

10.14 Relational integrity constraints

What it is

An **integrity constraint** is a condition stored data is never allowed to break. Whatever program connects, the DBMS tests it during each `INSERT`, `UPDATE` and `DELETE` and refuses any change that would violate it.

Figure – the integrity constraints and the SQL that declares each (course diagram)



Constraint	Rule	SQL
Domain	a value must be in the attribute's domain	the data type, plus `CHECK (capacity BETWEEN 1 AND 500)`
Entity integrity	no part of a primary key may be `NULL`	`PRIMARY KEY` (implies `NOT NULL`)
Key	candidate keys are unique	`PRIMARY KEY`, `UNIQUE`
Referential integrity	an FK value matches an existing referenced row, or is `NULL` – no **orphan rows**	`FOREIGN KEY … REFERENCES …`
(also declared the same way)	must always have a value / default when omitted	`NOT NULL`, `DEFAULT` (DEFAULT never refuses anything, so it is not strictly a constraint)

Why entity integrity: a primary key identifies a row, and `NULL` means "unknown" – a row with unknown identity cannot be distinguished, so the model rejects it. For composite keys *every* column must be present.

What happens when a referenced (parent) row is deleted or its key updated

Action (`ON DELETE` / `ON UPDATE`)	Effect	Use when
`NO ACTION` (default)	error if children exist; in PostgreSQL the check runs at the end of the statement and can be `DEFERRABLE` to end of transaction	general default
`RESTRICT`	error immediately, cannot be deferred	you want an immediate refusal
`CASCADE`	delete/update the children too	weak entities, pure child data (phones, order lines) – dangerous elsewhere
`SET NULL`	children's FK becomes `NULL` (column must be nullable)	optional relationships
`SET DEFAULT`	children's FK becomes its default	rare

Dialect notes: MySQL/InnoDB treats `NO ACTION` as `RESTRICT` and rejects `SET DEFAULT`; SQL Server has no `RESTRICT` keyword (use `NO ACTION`); SQLite enforces FKs only after `PRAGMA foreign_keys = ON`. MySQL enforces `CHECK` only from 8.0.16 (earlier versions parsed and ignored it).

Running it (`code/03_keys_and_integrity.sql`)

```
CREATE TABLE room (
  room_id  int PRIMARY KEY,                                  -- entity integrity: unique + NOT NULL
  code     varchar(10) NOT NULL UNIQUE,                      -- alternate (candidate) key
  capacity int NOT NULL CHECK (capacity BETWEEN 1 AND 500)   -- domain constraint
);
CREATE TABLE lecturer (
  lecturer_id int PRIMARY KEY,
  name        varchar(60) NOT NULL,
  email       varchar(120) UNIQUE,                           -- UNIQUE but nullable
  room_id     int REFERENCES room(room_id) ON DELETE SET NULL  -- optional link
);
CREATE TABLE booking (
  room_id  int  NOT NULL REFERENCES room(room_id) ON DELETE RESTRICT,
  day      date NOT NULL,
  slot     int  NOT NULL CHECK (slot BETWEEN 1 AND 8),
  PRIMARY KEY (room_id, day, slot)                           -- composite key
);
-- each violation is attempted inside:  DO $$ BEGIN ... EXCEPTION WHEN ... THEN RAISE NOTICE ... END $$;
```

Output:

```
--- 1. domain: capacity 900 is outside the allowed values
NOTICE:  new row for relation "room" violates check constraint "room_capacity_check"
--- 2. entity integrity: a primary key may not be NULL
NOTICE:  null value in column "room_id" of relation "room" violates not-null constraint
--- 3. key constraint: the alternate key code must be unique
NOTICE:  duplicate key value violates unique constraint "room_code_key"
--- 4. referential integrity: no orphan rows
NOTICE:  insert or update on table "booking" violates foreign key constraint "booking_room_id_fkey"
--- 5. UNIQUE lets several rows have NULL (Dr Silva and Dr Wu both have no email)
   name    | email
----------+-------
 Dr Silva |
 Dr Wu    |
(2 rows)

--- 6. ON DELETE RESTRICT: room 1 still has bookings
NOTICE:  update or delete on table "room" violates foreign key constraint "booking_room_id_fkey" on table
"booking"
--- 7. ON DELETE SET NULL: deleting room 2 empties Dr Silva's room_id
   name    | room_id
----------+---------
 Dr Park  |       1
 Dr Silva |
 Dr Wu    |
(3 rows)
```

UNIQUE and NULL — a classic surprise

Because `NULL` is never equal to `NULL`, most databases let a `UNIQUE` column hold **many** nulls (output 5). If "unique when present" is not what you want, add `NOT NULL`.

DBMS	Multiple NULLs in a UNIQUE column?
PostgreSQL	yes by default; PostgreSQL 15+ can say `UNIQUE NULLS NOT DISTINCT` to allow only one (not run here — our server is 14)
MySQL (InnoDB)	yes
SQLite	yes
SQL Server	**no — only one NULL**; use a filtered unique index `WHERE col IS NOT NULL` for "many"

Why rules belong in the schema

1. **They hold for everybody** — web app, mobile backend, nightly import, a hand-typed fix at midnight.
2. **They cannot drift** — one copy, not one per application.
3. **They document meaning** — the `CREATE TABLE` tells a reader what the data is.

Costs: constraints add a little work to each write, and a thoughtless `CASCADE` can wipe out far more rows than someone meant. Both are small next to the benefit of a single, central enforcement point.

Common mistakes

- Forgetting to declare alternate keys → two customers with the same email.
- `ON DELETE CASCADE` on a "real" relationship (deleting a customer silently deletes their invoices).
- Assuming a nullable `UNIQUE` column means "at most one missing".
- Leaving FKs off "for speed" — orphans appear and joins silently lose rows.

TL;DR

Domain (type + CHECK), entity integrity (PK never NULL), key (UNIQUE), referential (FK matches or NULL; choose RESTRICT/NO ACTION/CASCADE/SET NULL on delete). UNIQUE usually allows many NULLs. Put rules in the schema so they hold for every client.

10.15 Converting an ER diagram to tables

The procedure

Once the diagram is right, conversion is mechanical — one decision per construct:

#	ER construct	Relational result
1	Strong entity	a table; key attribute → primary key
2	Simple attribute	a column
3	Composite attribute	one column per part (no column for the whole)
4	Derived attribute	no column (compute in the query or a view)
5	Multivalued attribute	own table: owner key + value, both in the PK, `ON DELETE CASCADE`
6a	1:N / N:1 relationship	FK on the many side
6b	M:N relationship	junction table: both FKs, together the PK
6c	1:1 relationship	FK + `UNIQUE` on either side, prefer the total-participation side
6d	Unary relationship	FK to the same table
6e	Ternary relationship	table with three FKs (PK usually all three)
7	Relationship attribute	follows the relationship: junction table (M:N) or many side (1:N)
8	Weak entity	table with PK = owner key + partial key; owner FK `NOT NULL`, usually `ON DELETE CASCADE`
9	Participation	total → FK `NOT NULL`; partial → FK nullable

Create tables in **dependency order** — parents before children, since a foreign key can only point at a table that already exists.

Figure — the course's Employee/Payroll example as tables: the composite splits, the multivalued attribute becomes a table, the derived attributes vanish (course diagrams)

The same design as tables. Notice what happened to each kind of attribute.

Employee

column	came from
employee_id	key attribute
first_name	Full_Name, split in three
middle_initial	Full_Name, split in three
last_name	Full_Name, split in three
birthdate	simple attribute
gender	simple attribute
address	simple attribute
payroll_id	the 1:1 relationship

EmployeeContact

column
employee_id
contact_number

the multivalued attribute, given a table of its own

Payroll

payroll_id
monthly_salary, cash_advance
tax

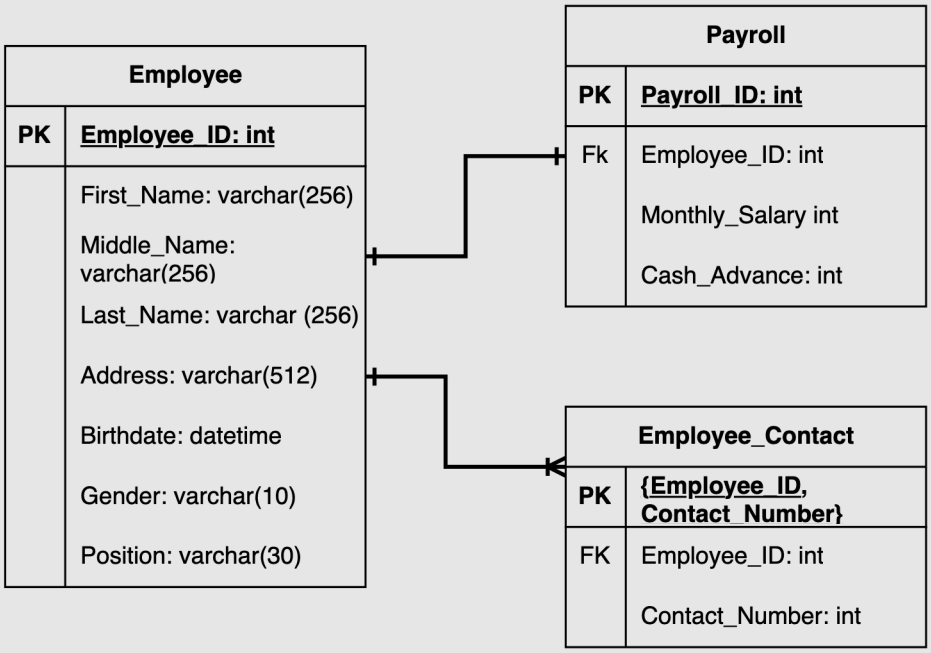
Columns that do not exist

age
derived from birthdate

net_pay
derived from salary, advance and tax

contact_number
multivalued, so it could not be a column at all

composite attribute	Full_Name became three columns, one per part
multivalued attribute	Contact_Number became its own table, because a cell holds one value
derived attribute	Age and Net_Pay became no column, and are calculated when read
one-to-one link	payroll_id on Employee, with a UNIQUE constraint to keep it one each way



Running the procedure on §10.10 (`code/02_employee_er_to_tables.sql`)

```
CREATE TABLE department (                       -- strong entity -> table
  dept_id   int PRIMARY KEY,
  dept_name varchar(60) NOT NULL UNIQUE
);
CREATE TABLE payroll (                          -- strong entity -> table
  payroll_id     int PRIMARY KEY,
  monthly_salary numeric(10,2) NOT NULL CHECK (monthly_salary >= 0),  -- stored (typed in)
  cash_advance   numeric(10,2) NOT NULL DEFAULT 0,
  tax            numeric(10,2) NOT NULL DEFAULT 0
  -- net_pay is DERIVED -> no column (computed in the view below)
);
CREATE TABLE employee (
  emp_id         int PRIMARY KEY,                              -- key attribute
  first_name     varchar(40) NOT NULL,                         -- composite attribute full_name
  middle_initial char(1),                                      --   split into
  last_name      varchar(40) NOT NULL,                         --   one column per part
  birth_date     date NOT NULL,                                -- simple; age is DERIVED
  dept_id        int  NOT NULL REFERENCES department(dept_id),  -- 1:N, total participation -> NOT NULL
  supervisor_id  int  REFERENCES employee(emp_id),             -- unary 1:N, partial -> NULL allowed
  payroll_id     int  NOT NULL UNIQUE REFERENCES payroll(payroll_id)  -- 1:1 -> FK + UNIQUE
);
CREATE TABLE employee_phone (                   -- multivalued attribute -> own table
  emp_id int         NOT NULL REFERENCES employee(emp_id) ON DELETE CASCADE,
  phone  varchar(20) NOT NULL,
  PRIMARY KEY (emp_id, phone)
);
CREATE TABLE project (project_id int PRIMARY KEY, title varchar(80) NOT NULL);
CREATE TABLE works_on (                         -- M:N -> junction table
  emp_id     int NOT NULL REFERENCES employee(emp_id),
  project_id int NOT NULL REFERENCES project(project_id),
  weekly_hours numeric(4,1) NOT NULL CHECK (weekly_hours > 0),  -- relationship attribute
  PRIMARY KEY (emp_id, project_id)
);
CREATE TABLE dependent (                        -- weak entity
  emp_id       int NOT NULL REFERENCES employee(emp_id) ON DELETE CASCADE,  -- owner key
  dep_name     varchar(40) NOT NULL,                                       -- partial key
  relationship varchar(20) NOT NULL,
  PRIMARY KEY (emp_id, dep_name)                                           -- owner key + partial key
);
-- Derived attributes live in a view (fixed "as of" date so the output is repeatable):
CREATE VIEW employee_card AS
SELECT e.emp_id,
       concat_ws(' ', e.first_name, e.middle_initial, e.last_name)   AS full_name,
       date_part('year', age(date '2026-09-28', e.birth_date))::int  AS age,
       p.monthly_salary - p.cash_advance - p.tax                    AS net_pay,
       (SELECT string_agg(phone, ', ' ORDER BY phone) FROM employee_phone ph
         WHERE ph.emp_id = e.emp_id)                                 AS phones
FROM employee e JOIN payroll p USING (payroll_id);
```

Output:

```
--- employee_card (derived: full_name, age, net_pay; multivalued: phones)
 emp_id |  full_name   | age | net_pay |              phones
--------+--------------+-----+---------+----------------------------------
      1 | Aisha Khan   |  41 | 4900.00 | +44 20 7946 0001
      2 | Ravi K Menon |  33 | 4250.00 | +91 80 4000 0003, +91 98450 00002
      3 | Sofia Rossi  |  28 | 3100.00 |
(3 rows)

--- the unary relationship: who reports to whom
 employee | supervisor
----------+------------
 Aisha    |
 Ravi     | Aisha
 Sofia    | Aisha
(3 rows)

--- 1:1 is enforced by UNIQUE: a second employee on payroll 501 is refused
NOTICE:  refused: duplicate key value violates unique constraint "employee_payroll_id_key"
--- weak entity: deleting the owner removes its dependents (ON DELETE CASCADE)
 dependents_left | phones_left
-----------------+-------------
               0 |           0
(1 row)
```

(Before deleting employee 2 the script first removes their `works_on` rows and clears the `supervisor_id` pointing at them, because those FKs use the default `NO ACTION` – the database would otherwise refuse, which is exactly referential integrity at work.)

Checking a conversion

1. **Count:** 5 entities + 1 multivalued attribute + 1 M:N relationship = 7 tables. ✓
2. **Every relationship produced something** (an FK, a UNIQUE FK or a table). A relationship that produced nothing was missed.
3. **No derived attribute survived** as a column – or, if one did, a comment says why.
4. **No multivalued attribute left in its parent** – a list column is a 1NF violation (Chapter 11).

TL;DR

Entities → tables; simple → columns; composite → parts; derived → nothing; multivalued → own table; 1:N → FK on many side; M:N → junction table; 1:1 → FK + UNIQUE; weak → owner key + partial key with CASCADE; total participation → NOT NULL. Parents first.

10.16 Best practices for ER → relational mapping

The procedure is mechanical for small diagrams; large ones need judgement in a few places.

Situation	Recommendation	Why / exception
Composite attribute	Store the parts; do **not** also store the whole. Build the whole in a query or view.	Two copies disagree after the first partial update. Exception: never query the parts → one column is fine.
Multivalued attribute	Always a separate table with a composite PK (owner key + value). Never numbered columns.	The composite PK stops the same phone being stored twice for one person.
Derived attribute	Compute on read. Store only if expensive *or* it must be frozen in time (order total at purchase prices) – and comment the column.	Otherwise the next engineer deletes it as a "mistake".
1:1 with total participation both sides	Probably one table. Keep two only for access control, row width, or mostly-absent optional data.	Two tables always joined 1:1 are cost without benefit.
M:N	The junction table is mandatory; relationship attributes live there; give it a business name (`enrolment`, `booking`) not `student_course`.	Add a surrogate key only if other tables must reference a single row – and keep `UNIQUE` on the pair so nobody enrols twice.
Weak entity with a surrogate key	Keep `UNIQUE (owner_key, partial_key)`.	Otherwise the rule the weak entity expressed is enforced nowhere.
Naming	One style for tables and columns; FKs named after their target; **role names** when two FKs hit the same table (`origin_airport_id`, `destination_airport_id`, not `airport_id_1/2`).	Readable joins.
Normalization	Run the normal forms over the result (Chapter 11); expect one or two further splits.	A careful ERD lands *near* 3NF, rarely exactly on it.
Large diagrams	Create parent tables before children and finish one area (say orders) before starting the next (inventory); record each choice you made that the rules left open (merged 1:1s, stored derived columns, surrogate keys on weak entities).	Those are the choices someone will question later.

Common mistakes

- Converting an M:N with an FK on one side (only works if it was really 1:N).
- Keeping `full_name` *and* `first_name` / `last_name`.
- Surrogate key on a junction table without the pair `UNIQUE`.
- Creating child tables before parents in a migration script.

In the interview

30-second answer (for "turn this ERD into tables"): "Each strong entity becomes a table with its key as PK. Composite attributes split into columns, derived ones are computed, multivalued ones get their own table. 1:N puts the FK on the many side, M:N gets a junction table holding both keys plus any relationship attributes, 1:1 is an FK with UNIQUE. A weak entity's PK combines its owner's key with its partial key, with cascade delete, and total participation means NOT NULL. Then I check the result against the normal forms."

- *Where does `grade` go in student-course?* → In the enrolment junction table.
- *Would you merge a 1:1?* → Yes unless access control, row width or sparse optional data justify splitting.

Self-check

1. Two FKs from `flight` to `airport` – how do you name them? → By role: `origin_airport_id`, `destination_airport_id`.

2. A junction table has a surrogate PK. What else must it have? → `UNIQUE` on the two FK columns.
3. Is the converted schema automatically in 3NF? → No; check it with the normal forms.

TL;DR

Split composites without keeping the whole; multivalued → table; derived → computed (unless frozen); question every total 1:1; junction tables hold relationship attributes and a unique pair; name by role; convert in dependency order; then normalize.

Key terms

Term	Meaning
Data model	picture of entities, attributes and relationships
Conceptual / logical / physical model	things + links / + attributes, keys, general types / + exact types, indexes for one DBMS
Data independence	changing storage (physical) or some schema details (logical) without changing applications
Entity type / instance / set	the kind / one member / all current members
Key, simple, composite, multivalued, derived attribute	identifies / one value / has parts / many values / computed
Relationship type / set	the association / the actual pairs
Degree	number of entity types in a relationship (unary, binary, ternary)
Cardinality (ER)	max instances per side: 1:1, 1:N, M:N
Participation	total (mandatory, double line) or partial (optional)
(min, max)	min = participation, max = cardinality
Junction table	table implementing an M:N relationship
Weak entity, owner, partial key (discriminator), identifying relationship	entity identified only with its owner, via owner key + partial key
Chen vs crow's-foot	ellipse/diamond notation vs attributes-in-box + line-end notation
Relation, tuple, attribute, domain	table, row, column, allowed values
Degree / cardinality (relation)	number of columns / number of rows
Schema vs instance	design vs current data
Superkey, candidate, primary, alternate, composite, foreign, natural, surrogate key	see §10.13
Prime / non-prime attribute	in some candidate key / in none
Domain, entity, key, referential integrity	allowed values / PK not NULL / uniqueness / FK matches or NULL
Orphan row	child row whose FK points at nothing
RESTRICT / NO ACTION / CASCADE / SET NULL / SET DEFAULT	what happens to children when a parent is deleted/updated

---

Chapter 10 TL;DR

- **Model before tables.** Entities (nouns) → tables, attributes → columns, relationships (verbs) → FKs or junction tables. A fact you do not model is a question you cannot answer.
- **Three levels:** conceptual (for the business), logical (attributes, keys, normalization), physical (types, indexes, one DBMS).
- **Process:** requirements + questions → entities → relationships → conceptual review → logical → physical → validate; loop back freely.
- **Best practices:** constraints in the schema, one naming style, dates as dates, money as `numeric`, explicit `NOT NULL`, surrogate PK + unique natural key, 3NF by default, index real queries.
- **ER notation:** Chen (rectangle, ellipse, diamond; double ellipse = multivalued, dashed = derived, double rectangle/diamond = weak) vs crow's foot (`||`, `o|`, `o{`, `|{`), which mermaid draws.
- **Relationships:** degree, cardinality, participation are three separate questions; (min,max) = (participation, cardinality).
- **Relational model (Codd 1970):** relations of atomic values, links by value, declarative queries; SQL tables allow duplicates unless keyed; `NULL` needs `IS NULL`.
- **Keys:** superkey ⊇ candidate (minimal) ⊇ primary; alternates get `UNIQUE`; prime = in any candidate key.
- **Integrity:** domain, entity, key, referential (+ ON DELETE choices); UNIQUE usually allows many NULLs.
- **Mapping:** composite → parts, multivalued → table, derived → view, 1:N → FK on many, M:N → junction, 1:1 → FK + UNIQUE, weak → owner key + partial key + CASCADE, total → NOT NULL. Then normalize — Chapter 11.

Next: Chapter 11 — Normalization, which checks a design for redundancy and splits tables safely.